

INTERMEDIATE

26 lessons · 156 puzzles from real Lichess games · Solutions on page 53

Name: _____ Club / group: _____

Colour Key



Basics

Must-know checkmates



Attack

Going for the King: traps and mating patterns



Defence

Stopping the attack



Tactics

Short combinations that win material



Strategy

Long-term plans: pawns and structure



Endgame

Few pieces left: promote, or hold the draw



Openings

The first moves and what they aim for

Contents

1	Scholar's Mate	p. 1 · puzzles p. 2	14	Famous Mating Patterns	p. 27 · puzzles p. 28
2	Stopping Scholar's Mate	p. 3 · puzzles p. 4	15	Fool's Mate & the Shilling	p. 29 · puzzles p. 30
3	The Fork	p. 5 · puzzles p. 6	16	Lasker Trap & Fishing Pole	p. 31 · puzzles p. 32
4	The Pin	p. 7 · puzzles p. 8	17	Italian Game	p. 33 · puzzles p. 34
5	The Skewer	p. 9 · puzzles p. 10	18	Spanish Game	p. 35 · puzzles p. 36
6	Discovered Attack	p. 11 · puzzles p. 12	19	French Defence	p. 37 · puzzles p. 38
7	Back-Rank Mate	p. 13 · puzzles p. 14	20	Dutch Defence	p. 39 · puzzles p. 40
8	Removing the Defender	p. 15 · puzzles p. 16	21	Fried Liver Attack	p. 41 · puzzles p. 42
9	Pawn Weaknesses	p. 17 · puzzles p. 18	22	Jobava London	p. 43 · puzzles p. 44
10	Pawn Chains & Captures	p. 19 · puzzles p. 20	23	Petrov Defence	p. 45 · puzzles p. 46
11	How to Promote	p. 21 · puzzles p. 22	24	Philidor Defence	p. 47 · puzzles p. 48
12	How to Get Stalemated	p. 23 · puzzles p. 24	25	London System	p. 49 · puzzles p. 50
13	Basic Checkmates	p. 25 · puzzles p. 26	26	Modern Defence	p. 51 · puzzles p. 52

© 2026 Sergey V. Popov. Licensed under **CC BY-NC 4.0** (creativecommons.org/licenses/by-nc/4.0/): you may copy and share this work for non-commercial purposes, with credit to the author. Commercial use requires permission.
Games from the Lichess open database (CC0). Chess pieces: Noto Sans Symbols 2 (SIL Open Font License).

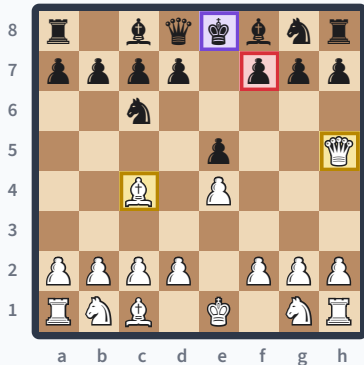
SCHOLAR'S MATE

Queen + Bishop vs. f7 • Checkmate in 4 moves

Lesson 1 • Attack
Level 1 Checkmating Patterns

1. The Setup

TWO PIECES AIM AT F7



1. e4 e5 2. Bc4 Nc6 3. Qh5

- At the start, **f7** is guarded only by the King. It is Black's weakest square.
- White's Queen (**h5**) and Bishop (**c4**) now both aim at it. Two attackers vs. one defender!

2. The Checkmate

4.Qxf7# GAME OVER

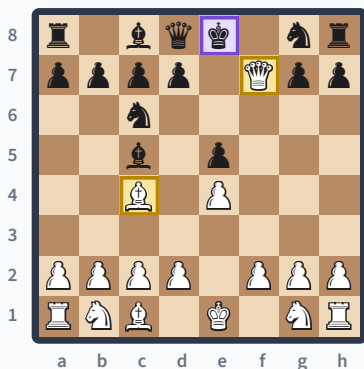


3... Nf6?? 4. Qxf7#

- 3...Nf6??** attacks the Queen but forgets the threat.
- 4.Qxf7#**
- The King can't take (the **c4**-Bishop guards f7) and its own pieces block every escape.

3. The Qf3 Version

SAME IDEA, NEW ROUTE

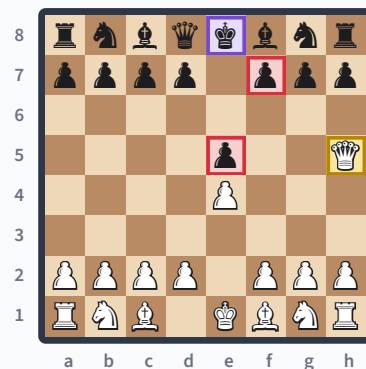


2. Bc4 Bc5 3. Qf3 Nc6?? 4. Qxf7#

- The Queen can also come in on the **f**-file from **f3**. Same target, same mate.
- Always ask: "What is my opponent's last move threatening?"

4. The Wayward Queen

2.QH5 HITS E5 + F7



1. e4 e5 2. Qh5

- The Queen comes out on move 2, hitting **e5** and eyeing **f7**. Guard e5 first: **2...Nc6!**
- Not **2...g6??** 3. Qxe5+, which forks the King and the **h8**-Rook.

Why It Works, and Why It Stops Working

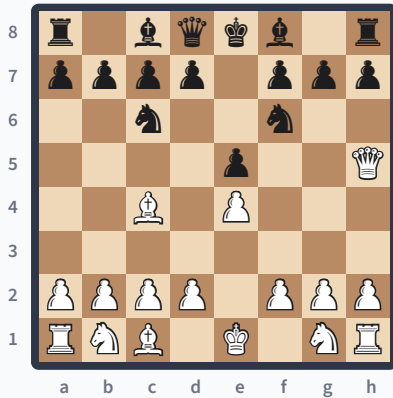
- f7 (and f2 for White) is the weak spot:** only the King defends it at the start of the game.
- Two beats one:** Queen + Bishop = two attackers. Checkmate comes when the defender doesn't add a second guard.
- It's a gamble:** against a player who knows the defence (page 3), White's Queen gets chased around and Black develops for free.

PUZZLES: SCHOLAR'S MATE

Find the mate: six positions from real Lichess games

Lesson 1 · Attack Puzzles
Level 1 Checkmating Patterns

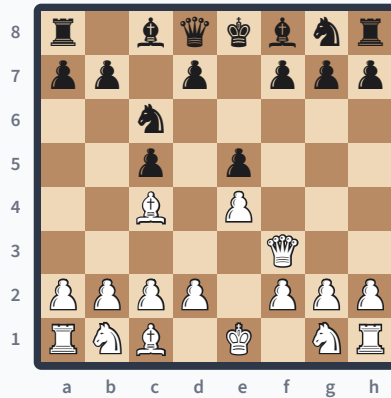
1 White to move. Checkmate in 1!



White (1659) v Black (1268) · 10+0
lichess.org/L1BiuKiK

Answer: _____

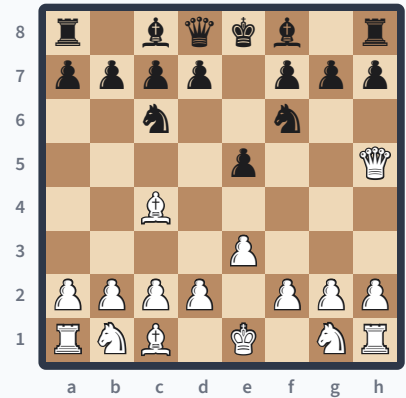
2 White to move. Checkmate in 1!



White (1470) v Black (1001) · 15+0
lichess.org/Y37Qw9QN

Answer: _____

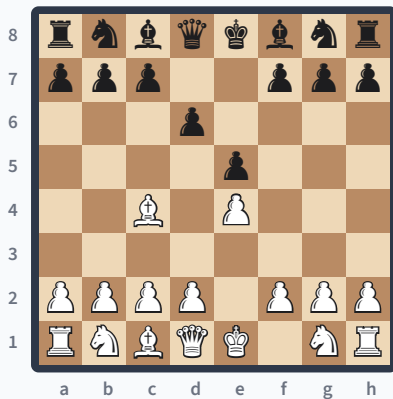
3 White to move. Checkmate in 1!



White (1178) v Black (1339) · 25+0
lichess.org/ctq876mg

Answer: _____

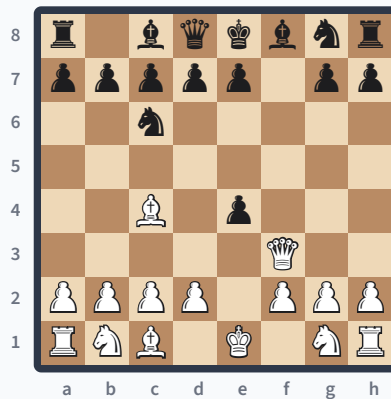
4 White to move. Which Queen move threatens mate on f7?



White (1620) v Black (1278) · 15+0
lichess.org/rThGMIRV

Answer: _____

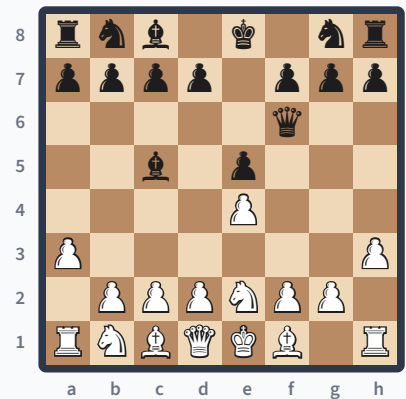
5 White to move. Checkmate in 1. There are TWO ways!



White (1285) v Black (1279) · 10+0
lichess.org/u8ggaevt

Answer: _____

6 Black to move. Black can do it too! Checkmate in 1.



White (1605) v Black (1735) · 10+0
lichess.org/MquSlnPb

Answer: _____

Tip: look for the Queen + Bishop team on f7 (or f2). If f7 is attacked twice and defended once, it may be mate!

Score: ____ / 6

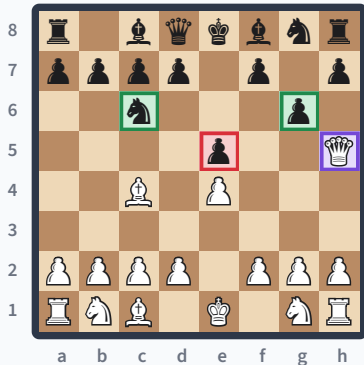
STOPPING SCHOLAR'S MATE

Guard f7, kick the Queen, develop with tempo

Lesson 2 · Defence
Level 1 Checkmating Patterns

1. Kick the Queen

3...G6! BLOCK + ATTACK



1.e4 e5 2.Bc4 Nc6 3.Qh5 g6!

- **3...g6!** cuts the Queen off from f7 AND attacks it. The Queen must move again.
- Safe here because the **c6**-Knight already guards **e5**.

2. The Solid Way

3...QE7 GUARDS F7

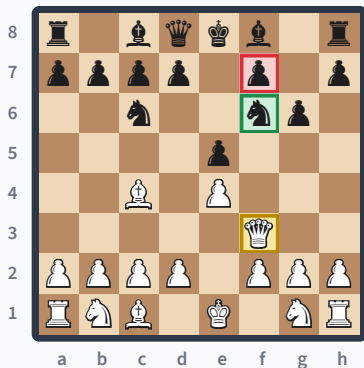


1.e4 e5 2.Bc4 Nc6 3.Qh5 Qe7

- **3...Qe7** adds a second guard to **f7** (and to **e5**). Now it's two vs. two.
- Next, ...Nf6 develops and kicks the White Queen away.

3. Second Try: Qf3

4...NF6! BLOCKS F-FILE



3...g6 4.Qf3 Nf6!

- White renews the threat on **f7** from **f3**. **4...Nf6!** steps into the Queen's path.
- Blocking with a developing piece is the best defence: it defends AND gets a piece out.

4. Chase It Again

6...ND4! TEMPO



5.Qb3 Qe7 6.Nc3 Nd4!

- **5...Qe7** guards f7 one more time. Then **6...Nd4!** hits the Queen again and eyes **c2**.
- White's Queen has moved 3 times and must move a 4th. Black is ahead in development.

Defender's Checklist

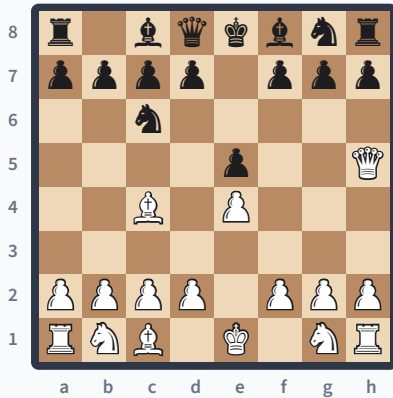
White plays...	Black answers...	Why
Qh5 (hits e5)	...Nc6	Guard e5 first, with a developing move
Qh5 + Bc4 (hit f7)	...g6 or ...Qe7	Block the Queen, or add a second guard to f7
Qf3 (hits f7 again)	...Nf6	Block the f-file and develop
Queen keeps wandering	Develop with tempo	Every move that attacks the Queen gains you time

PUZZLES: DEFENCE

Stopping Scholar's Mate: six positions from real Lichess games

Lesson 2 · Defence Puzzles
Level 1 Checkmating Patterns

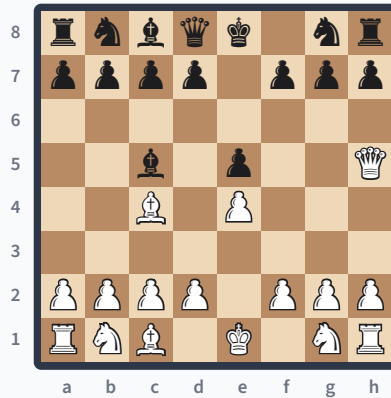
- 1** Black to move. White threatens mate! What should Black play?



White (958) v Black (1274) · 5+5
lichess.org/y44Msw6h

Answer: _____

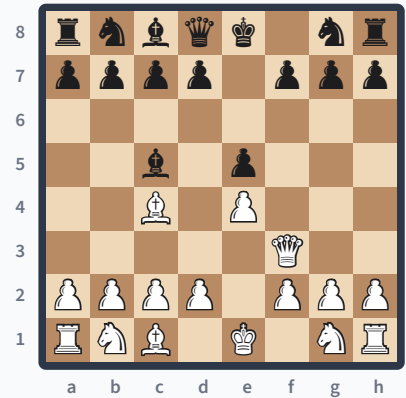
- 2** Black to move. Defend f7 AND e5 with one move.



White (1271) v Black (1130) · 8+0
lichess.org/Uiq79Uha

Answer: _____

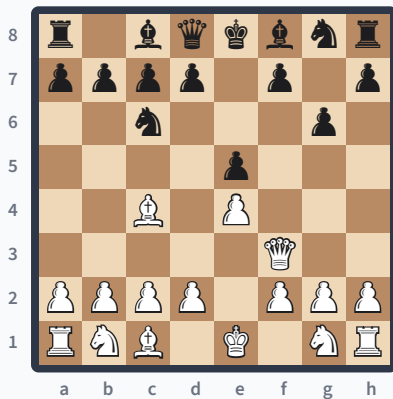
- 3** Black to move. The Qf3 version! How do you stop mate?



White (1476) v Black (1500) · 9+0
lichess.org/cX7tWS2B

Answer: _____

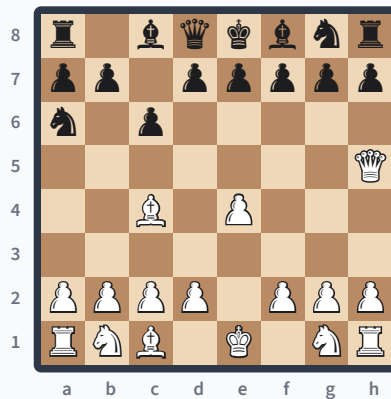
- 4** Black to move. The Queen came back on f3. What now?



White (1175) v Black (1673) · 20+0
lichess.org/8lxKa1LZ

Answer: _____

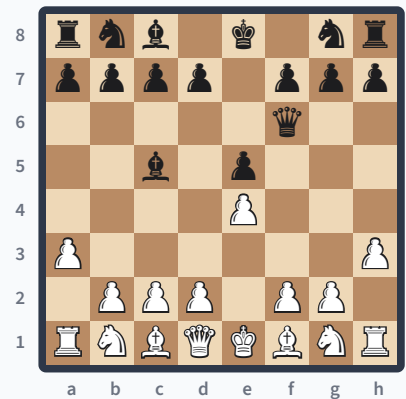
- 5** Black to move. Not 1...e5 this time, but f7 is still in danger!



White (1230) v Black (1170) · 7+3
lichess.org/hkkLApVi

Answer: _____

- 6** White to move. Black threatens mate! How do you stop it?



White (1614) v Black (1727) · 10+0
lichess.org/by9VPjru

Answer: _____

Tip: before every move, ask: "Is my f7 (or f2) pawn attacked twice?" If yes, block, defend or kick the Queen.

Score: ____ / 6

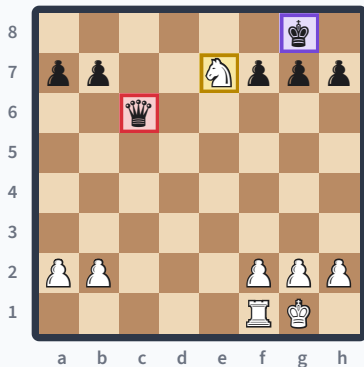
THE FORK

One piece, two targets • The Double Attack

Lesson 3 • Tactics
Level 1 Tactical Concepts

1. The Knight Fork

NE7+! ROYAL FORK



White to play: 1.Ne7+!

- The Knight checks the King on **g8** AND attacks the Queen on **c6** at the same time.
- Black must save the King (1...Kh8), then **2.Nxc6** wins the Queen for a Knight.

2. The Pawn Fork

5...d5! FORK TRICK



4.Bc4 Nxe4! 5.Nxe4 d5!

- Black gives the Knight back on **e4** for a moment...
- ...then the humble pawn **5...d5!** forks Bishop and Knight. One falls, and Black gets a great centre.

3. The Queen Fork

4...Qg5! DOUBLE HIT

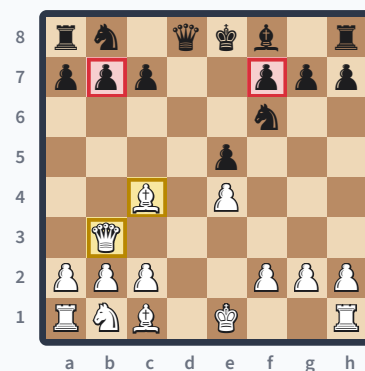


3...Nd4 4.Nxe5? Qg5!

- 4.Nxe5?** grabs a pawn, but **4...Qg5!** attacks the Knight on **e5** AND the pawn on **g2**.
- If **5.Nxf7??** then **5...Qxg2** **6.Rf1 Qxe4+** **7.Be2 Nf3#**. Queens are fork machines!

4. Two Targets, One Move

7.Qb3! F7 + B7



6.Bc4 Nf6 7.Qb3!

- Morphy's Opera Game (1858): **7.Qb3!** hits **b7** and, teamed with the c4-Bishop, **f7**.
- Black can't guard both. **7...Qe7** saves f7 but leaves b7 hanging.

How to Spot a Fork

- Look for loose pieces:** an unprotected piece is a fork waiting to happen. Coaches say "LPDO": Loose Pieces Drop Off.
- Checks first:** a fork with check is the deadliest kind. The King must be saved, so the second target falls.
- Knight radar:** a Knight can only fork pieces standing on the *same colour* squares. Two enemy pieces on the same colour? Hunt for the Knight square that hits both.

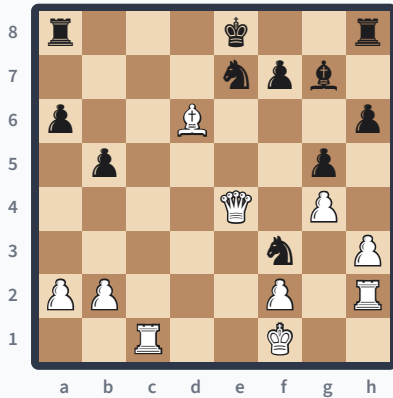
PUZZLES: THE FORK

Six positions from real Lichess games

Lesson 3 · Tactics Puzzles

Level 1 Tactical Concepts

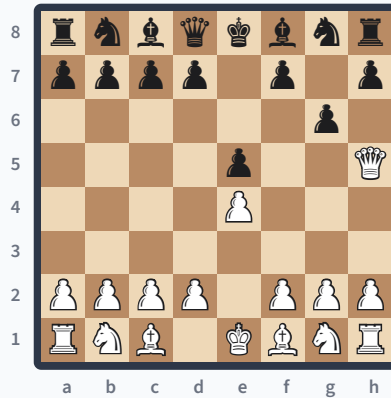
1 Black to move. Find the fork!



White (1552) v Black (1607) · 15+20
lichess.org/yay9t80W

Answer: _____

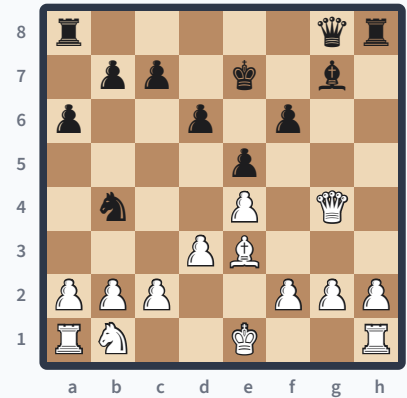
2 White to move. Find the fork!



White (1422) v Black (1065) · 12+3
lichess.org/AZm8oHjW

Answer: _____

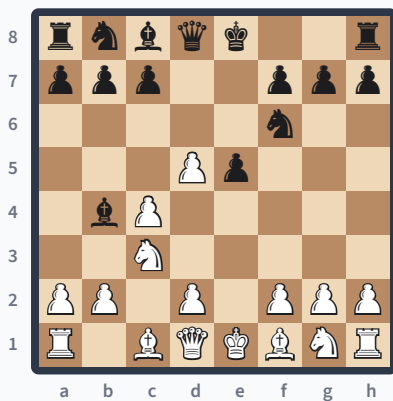
3 Black to move. Find the fork!



White (1696) v Black (1695) · 10+0
lichess.org/QmeDOLbf

Answer: _____

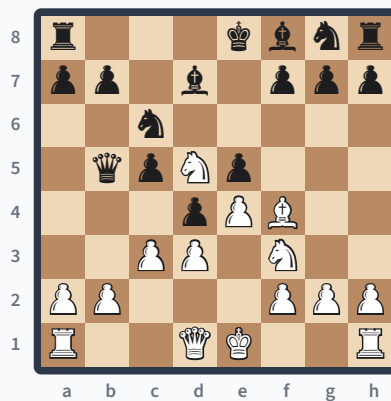
4 White to move. Find the fork!



White (1407) v Black (1620) · 10+5
lichess.org/fqAbUtr1

Answer: _____

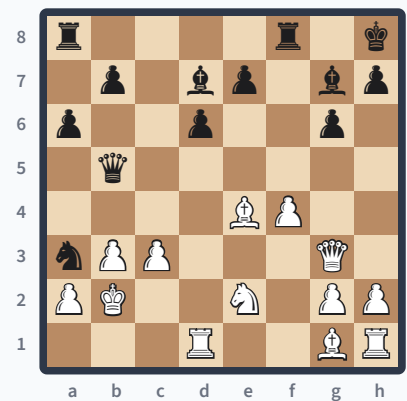
5 White to move. Find the fork!



White (1460) v Black (1389) · 15+0
lichess.org/zTRG9bj0

Answer: _____

6 Black to move. Find the fork!



White (1759) v Black (1934) · 10+0
lichess.org/KohsXbaK

Answer: _____

Tip: look for one square where your piece attacks two things at once, best of all with check.

Score: ____ / 6

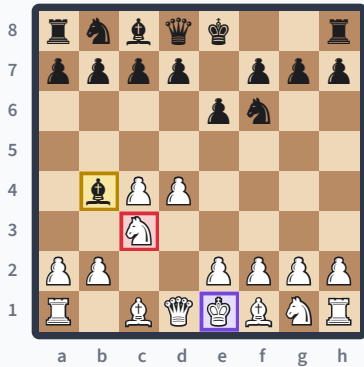
THE PIN

Frozen pieces can't defend • Absolute & Relative Pins

Lesson 4 • Tactics
Level 1 Tactical Concepts

1. Absolute Pin

3...Bb4 PINS C3



1.d4 Nf6 2.c4 e6 3.Nc3 Bb4

- **3...Bb4** (the Nimzo-Indian) pins White's c3-Knight to the King on e1.
- **Absolute pin:** moving the Knight would put its own King in check, so it is *illegal*.

2. Relative Pin

4.Bg5 PINS F6

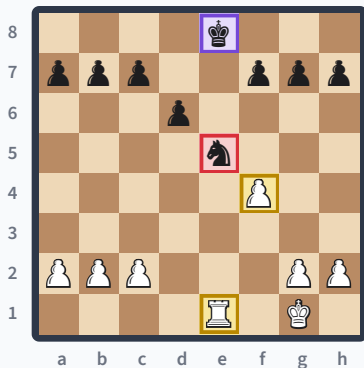


1.d4 d5 2.c4 e6 3.Nc3 Nf6 4.Bg5

- **4.Bg5** pins Black's f6-Knight to the Queen on d8.
- **Relative pin:** the Knight *may* move, but the Queen would be lost. Legal is not the same as safe!

3. Attack the Pinned Piece

1.f4! PILE ON

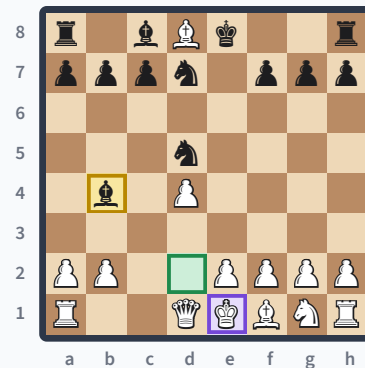


White to play: 1.f4!

- The e5-Knight is pinned to its King by the Rook on e1. It cannot move.
- **1.f4!** attacks it with a pawn. The Knight can't run, so White wins a piece for a pawn.

4. The Elephant Trap

6.Nxd5?? BLUNDER



6.Nxd5?? Nxd5! 7.Bxd8 Bb4+

- After 4...Nbd7 5.cxd5 exd5, White grabs d5, thinking the f6-Knight is pinned. It's only *relative*!
- After **8.Qd2 Bxd2+ 9.Kxd2 Kxd8**, Black is a Knight up for a pawn.

Comparison: Fork vs. Pin

Feature	The Fork	The Pin
How it works	One piece attacks two targets at once	A piece can't move without exposing a bigger one behind it
Who can do it	Any piece, even pawns and Kings	Only line pieces: Bishop, Rook, Queen
Best targets	King + an unprotected piece	A piece standing in front of its King or Queen
How to defend	Don't leave pieces loose on fork squares	Break it: move the King/Queen, block, or attack the pinner

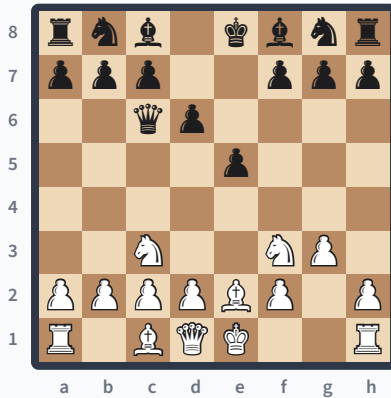
PUZZLES: THE PIN

Six positions from real Lichess games

Lesson 4 · Tactics Puzzles

Level 1 Tactical Concepts

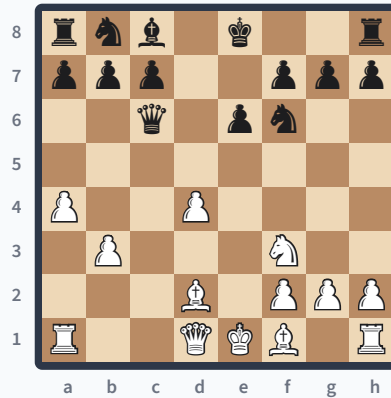
- 1** White to move. Win material with a pin!



White (1574) v Black (1594) · 5+5
lichess.org/r4d18h4h

Answer: _____

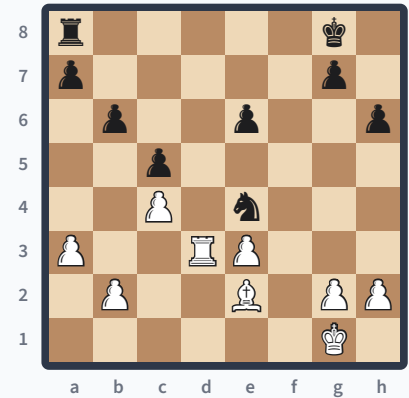
- 2** White to move. Win material with a pin!



White (1353) v Black (1192) · 10+0
lichess.org/FFSn9BqV

Answer: _____

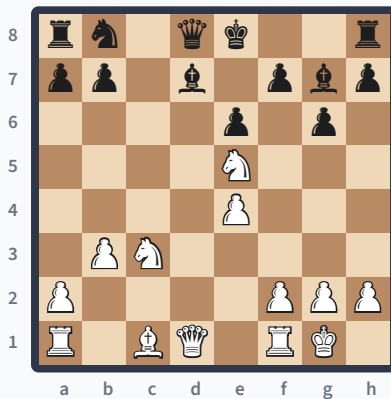
- 3** White to move. Win material with a pin!



White (1599) v Black (1609) · 10+0
lichess.org/ahe2pKXN

Answer: _____

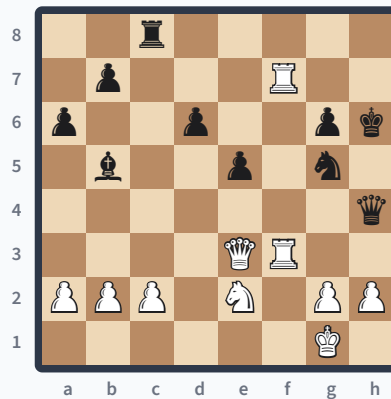
- 4** Black to move. Win material with a pin!



White (1299) v Black (1585) · 5+8
lichess.org/6tbKntr1

Answer: _____

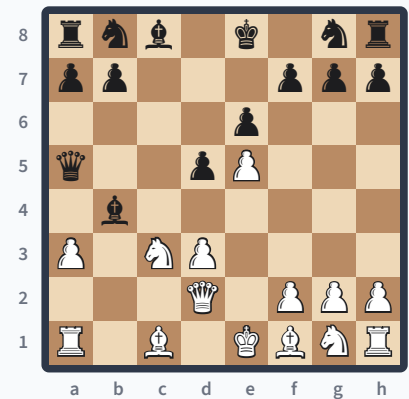
- 5** Black to move. Win material with a pin!



White (1731) v Black (1711) · 15+15
lichess.org/rWOu6AiH

Answer: _____

- 6** Black to move. Win material with a pin!



White (1500) v Black (1394) · 5+5
lichess.org/gjo8uAMJ

Answer: _____

Tip: find a piece standing in front of its King or Queen, then attack it along the line.

Score: ____ / 6

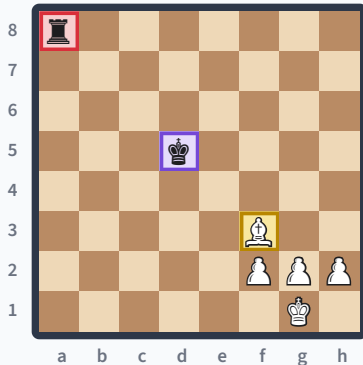
THE SKEWER

The pin turned inside-out • Big piece in front, prize behind

Lesson 5 • Tactics
Level 1 Tactical Concepts

1. Bishop Skewer

BF3+! WINS ROOK

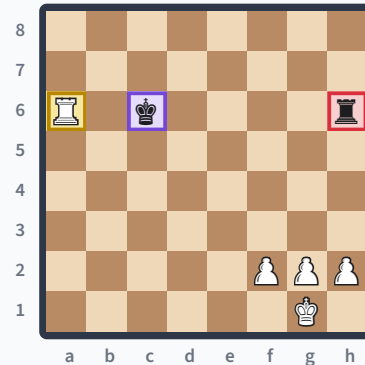


White to play: 1.Bf3+!

- **1.Bf3+** checks the King on **d5**. The Rook on **a8** is hiding on the same diagonal.
- The King must step off the line, then **2.Bxa8** collects the Rook.

2. Rook Skewer

RA6+! ON THE RANK

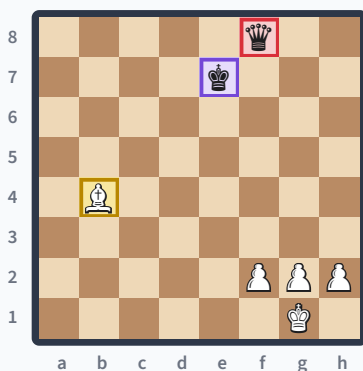


White to play: 1.Ra6+!

- Skewers work along ranks and files too. **1.Ra6+** checks the King on **c6**...
- ...and once it moves, **2.Rxh6** wins the Rook. A classic in Rook endgames!

3. King-to-Queen Skewer

BB4+! WINS QUEEN

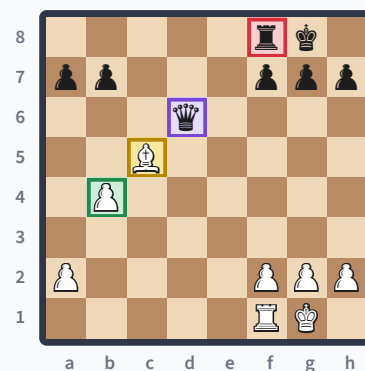


White to play: 1.Bb4+!

- **1.Bb4+** checks the King on **e7**, and the Queen stands right behind it on **f8**.
- Wherever the King goes, **2.Bxf8** wins the Queen for (at most) a Bishop.

4. Queen-to-Rook Skewer

BC5! WINS EXCHANGE



White to play: 1.Bc5!

- No check needed: **1.Bc5!** hits the Queen, with the **f8**-Rook behind. The **b4**-pawn guards the Bishop.
- The Queen must move, then **2.Bxf8** wins a Rook for a Bishop ("winning the exchange").

How to Spot a Skewer

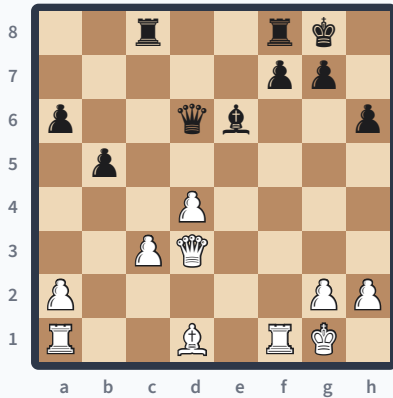
1. **Look for lines:** are two enemy pieces on the same rank, file or diagonal with nothing between them? That's skewer territory.
2. **Big one in front:** the King or Queen must be the *front* piece. It has to move, and the piece behind it is left hanging.
3. **Endgame alert:** Kings walk into the open in endgames, so skewers with check are everywhere. Before you move your King, check the lines!

PUZZLES: THE SKEWER

Six positions from real Lichess games

Lesson 5 · Tactics Puzzles
Level 1 Tactical Concepts

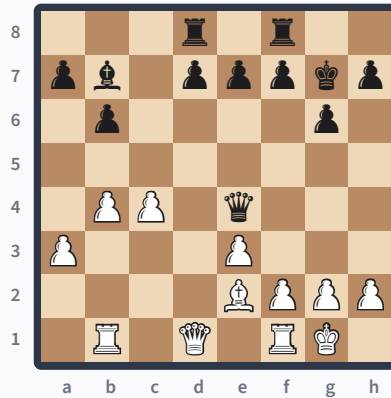
1 Black to move. Find the skewer!



White (1647) v Black (1635) · 10+0
lichess.org/q6FmC8ld

Answer: _____

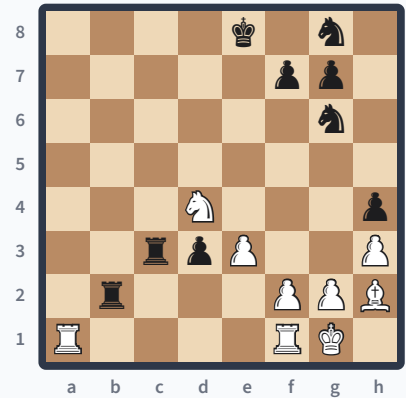
2 White to move. Find the skewer!



White (1875) v Black (1568) · 10+0
lichess.org/Mtuuwb4x

Answer: _____

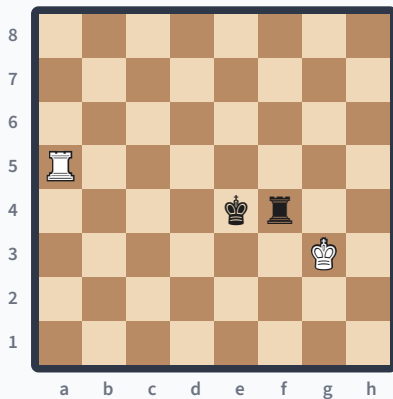
3 White to move. Find the skewer!



White (1568) v Black (1578) · 15+0
lichess.org/BGwJ9Mfs

Answer: _____

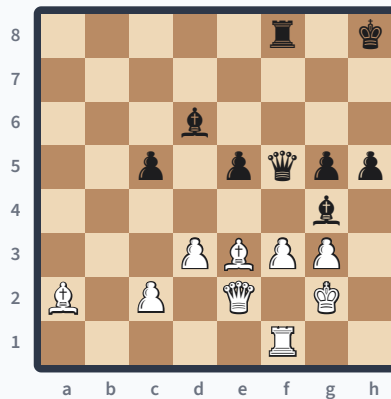
4 White to move. Find the skewer!



White (1504) v Black (1241) · 5+5
lichess.org/qbK48KHH

Answer: _____

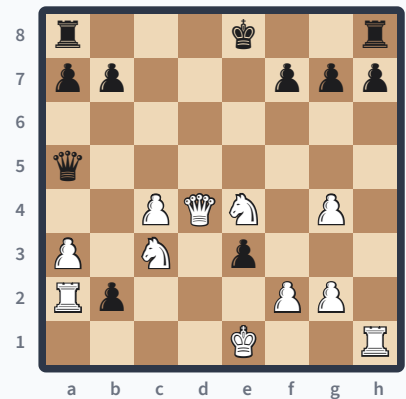
5 Black to move. Find the skewer!



White (1456) v Black (1472) · 8+0
lichess.org/RifoRB7V

Answer: _____

6 Black to move. Find the skewer!



White (1224) v Black (1222) · 10+0
lichess.org/AM2il450

Answer: _____

Tip: attack the big piece first. When it steps away, take the piece behind it.

Score: ____ / 6

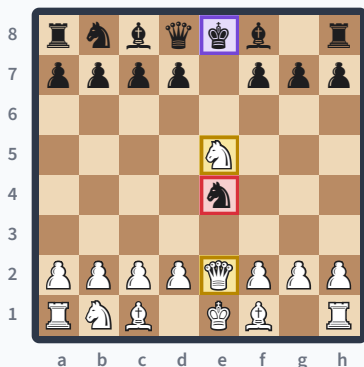
DISCOVERED ATTACK

Move one piece, unleash another • Hidden threats

Lesson 6 • Tactics
Level 2 Tactical Concepts

1. Loading the Battery

4.QE2! E-FILE

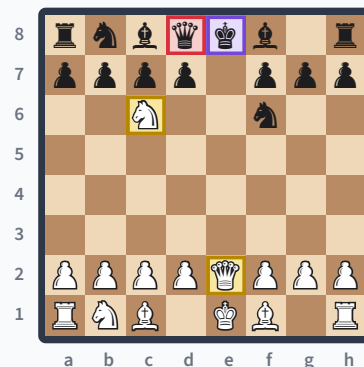


2.Nf3 Nf6 3.Nxe5 Nxe4? 4.Qe2!

- Copying White with 3...Nxe4? walks into 4.Qe2!, which attacks the Knight on e4.
- The Queen now hides behind the e5-Knight, aimed straight at Black's King on e8.

2. Discovered Check!

5.NC6+! WINS QUEEN

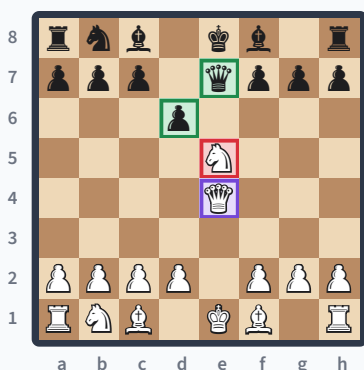


4...Nf6?? 5.Nc6+!

- The Knight jumps away and *uncovers* check from the Queen on e2...
- ...while attacking the Queen on d8. Black must answer the check, then 6.Nxd8.

3. The Right Defence

4...QE7! BLOCK THE LINE

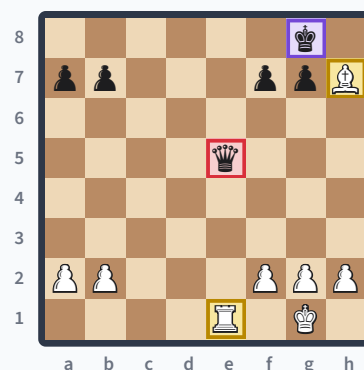


4...Qe7! 5.Qxe4 d6

- Black's Queen blocks the e-file. Now the e5-Knight is pinned to White's Queen and hit by d6.
- Black wins the piece back. Best of all: play 3...d6! first, and only then ...Nxe4.

4. Check + Hidden Rook

BXh7+! WINS QUEEN



1.Bxh7+! Kxh7 2.Rxe5

- The Bishop on e4 was blocking the e1-Rook. 1.Bxh7+! moves it away WITH check...
- ...so Black has no time to save the Queen on e5. A discovered attack wins it.

Line-Up Tactics: Pin vs. Skewer vs. Discovered Attack

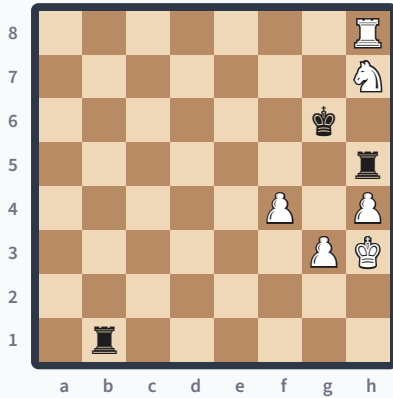
Tactic	Front piece	What happens	Look for...
Pin	Enemy's weaker piece	It is frozen: moving loses the big piece behind	Pieces in front of their King or Queen
Skewer	Enemy's stronger piece	It must move, and the piece behind falls	A King or Queen with a piece behind it
Discovered	YOUR own piece	It steps aside: two threats at once	Your pieces blocking your Rook, Bishop or Queen

PUZZLES: DISCOVERED ATTACK

Six positions from real Lichess games

Lesson 6 · Tactics Puzzles
Level 2 Tactical Concepts

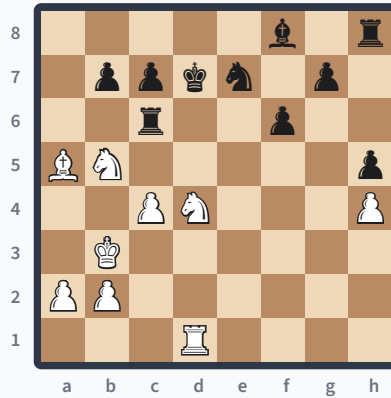
- 1** White to move. Find the discovered attack!



White (1335) v Black (1371) · 10+8
lichess.org/XSpEJl5F

Answer: _____

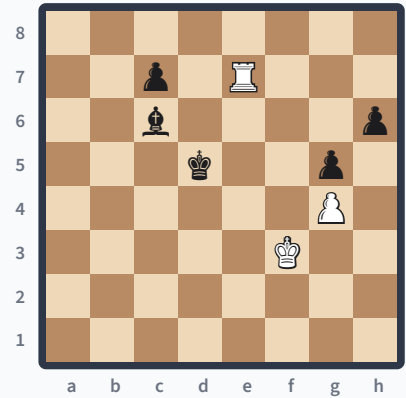
- 2** White to move. Find the discovered attack!



White (1481) v Black (1235) · 10+0
lichess.org/Li5JezeR

Answer: _____

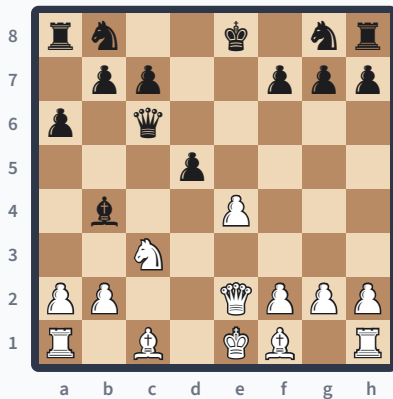
- 3** Black to move. Find the discovered attack!



White (1639) v Black (1663) · 5+5
lichess.org/2GqMczDY

Answer: _____

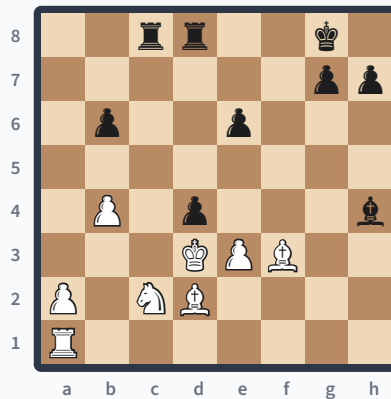
- 4** White to move. Find the discovered attack!



White (1412) v Black (1337) · 9+0
lichess.org/fi3ZlwYP

Answer: _____

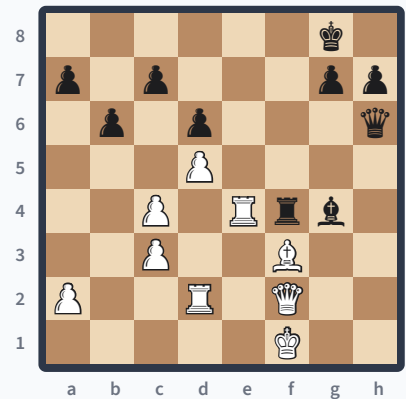
- 5** Black to move. Find the discovered attack!



White (1555) v Black (1484) · 8+0
lichess.org/5LgwgNr5

Answer: _____

- 6** Black to move. Find the discovered attack!



White (2095) v Black (1947) · 10+0
lichess.org/XtlmMajc

Answer: _____

Tip: move the front piece WITH a threat, and the piece behind it attacks too.

Score: ____ / 6

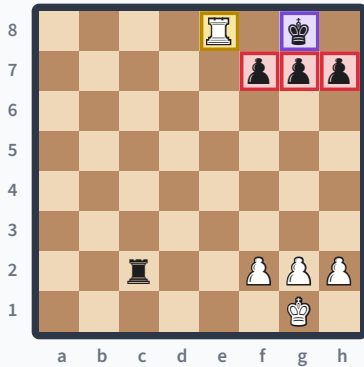
BACK-RANK MATE

Trapped by its own pawns • The #1 beginner checkmate

Lesson 7 • Attack
Level 1 Checkmating Patterns

1. The Pattern

RE8# CHECKMATE

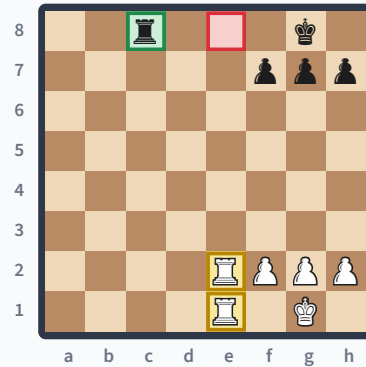


White to play: 1.Re8#

- Black's Rook went pawn-hunting on c2. **1.Re8#** is checkmate!
- The King is boxed in by its own **f7, g7, h7** pawns. No escape square, nothing can block.

2. Outnumber the Defender

DOUBLED ROOKS

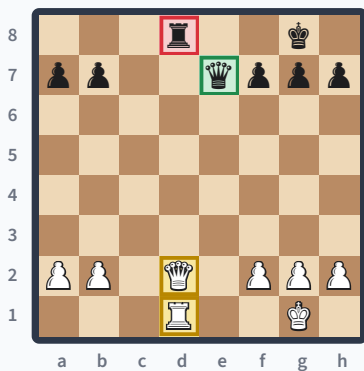


1.Re8+! Rxe8 2.Rxe8#

- Black's **c8**-Rook guards the back rank, but it can only do that once.
- White has TWO attackers on **e8**. First Rook is traded, second one mates. Two beats one!

3. Queen Sacrifice!

1.QXD8+!! MATES

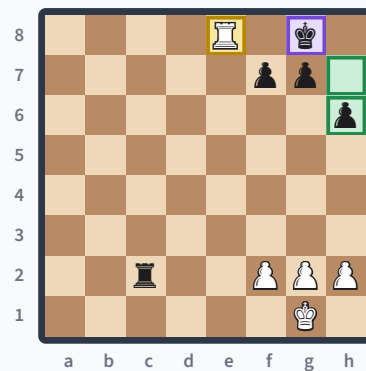


1.Qxd8+!! Qxd8 2.Rxd8#

- Two attackers (Qd2 + Rd1) against two defenders (Rd8 + Qe7), but the attacker goes first!
- Blocking with **1...Qe8** allows **2.Qxe8#**. **1...Qf8** just loses a whole Rook.

4. The Cure: Make Luft

...H6 ESCAPE HATCH



1.Re8+ Kh7 (safe!)

- Same as #1, but Black played **...h6** earlier. Now **1.Re8+** is only check: the King walks to **h7**.
- "Luft" is German for "air": a pawn move that gives your King a breathing hole.

3 Back-Rank Rules

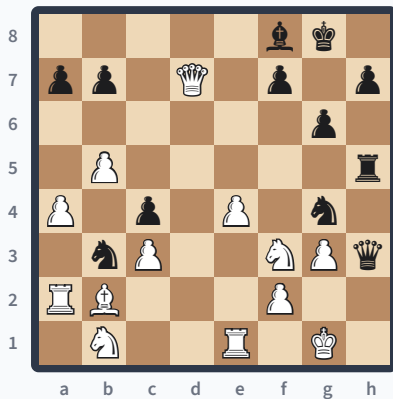
1. **Before you grab:** when your Rook or Queen leaves home to take a pawn, ask "who is guarding my back rank now?"
2. **Make luft in time:** after castling, a quiet h3 (or ...h6 for Black) when you have a spare move can save the whole game.
3. **Count the square:** attackers vs. defenders on the mating square. If you have more (or you move first!), look for the sacrifice.

PUZZLES: BACK-RANK MATE

Six positions from real Lichess games

Lesson 7 · Attack Puzzles
Level 1 Checkmating Patterns

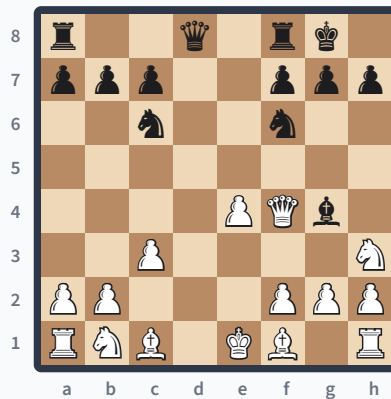
1 Black to move. Back-rank mate in 1!



White (1463) v Black (1500) · 17+0
lichess.org/e6i6lqWz

Answer: _____

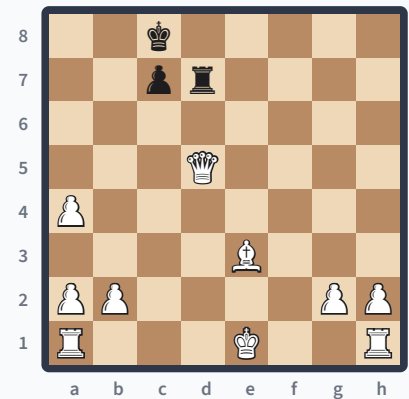
2 Black to move. Back-rank mate in 1!



White (1635) v Black (2131) · 8+8
lichess.org/UlzzklrU

Answer: _____

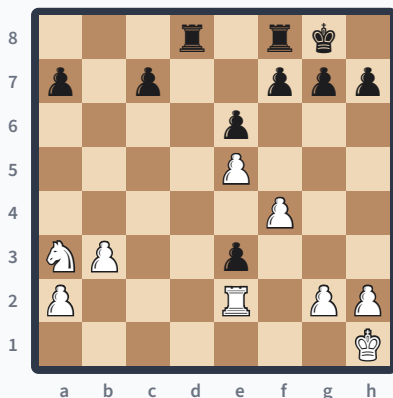
3 White to move. Back-rank mate in 1!



White (1241) v Black (1112) · 10+0
lichess.org/XpjeAYkl

Answer: _____

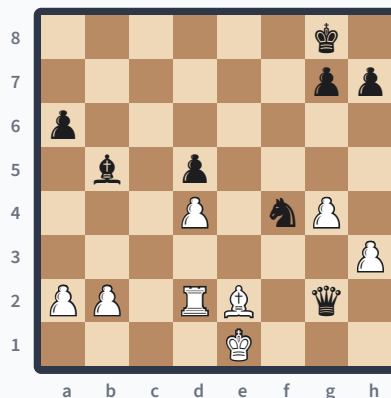
4 Black to move. Back-rank mate in 2!



White (1265) v Black (1179) · 10+0
lichess.org/7l0DF0Fu

Answer: _____

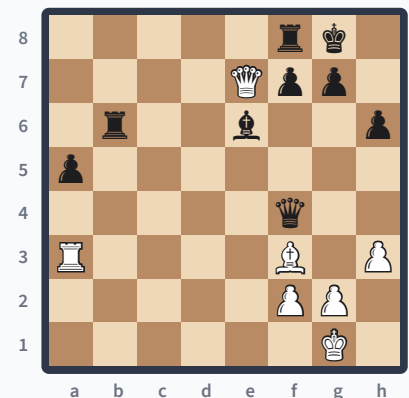
5 Black to move. Back-rank mate in 2!



White (1619) v Black (1820) · 10+0
lichess.org/q8QwC8ET

Answer: _____

6 Black to move. Back-rank mate in 2!



White (1655) v Black (1673) · 10+0
lichess.org/ZjMwWVg6

Answer: _____

Tip: King on the back row, pawns in front, no escape square: a Rook or Queen check may be mate.

Score: ____ / 6

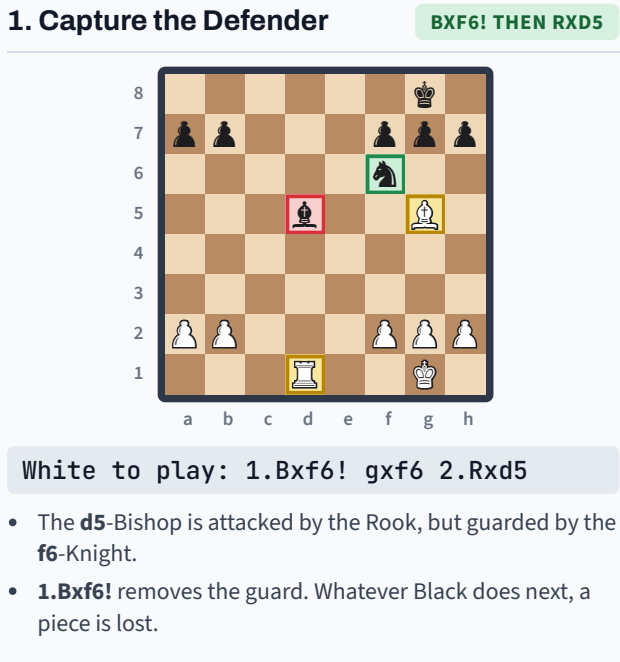
REMOVING THE DEFENDER

Take away the guard, take the prize • Capture, Chase, Overload

REMOVING THE DEFENDER

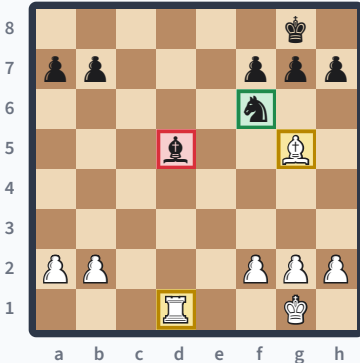
Take away the guard, take the prize • Capture, Chase, Overload

BXF6! THEN RXD5



1. Capture the Defender

BXF6! THEN RXD5

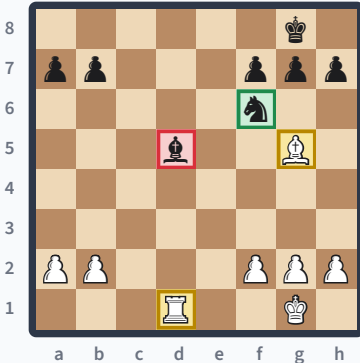


The diagram shows a chessboard with the following pieces: White King on g1, Queen on d1, Rook on a1, Bishop on d5, Knight on f6, Pawns on b2, c2, e2, f2, g2, h2. Black King on g8, Queen on d8, Rook on f6, Knight on e6, Pawns on a7, b7, c7, e7, f7, g7, h7. The Bishop on d5 is highlighted in red, the Knight on f6 in green, and the Rook on f6 in yellow. The squares d5, f6, and g6 are also highlighted in yellow.

White to play: 1.Bxf6! gxf6 2.Rxd5

- The **d5**-Bishop is attacked by the Rook, but guarded by the **f6**-Knight.
- **1.Bxf6!** removes the guard. Whatever Black does next, a piece is lost.

- # 1. Capture the Defender
- BXF6! THEN RXD5

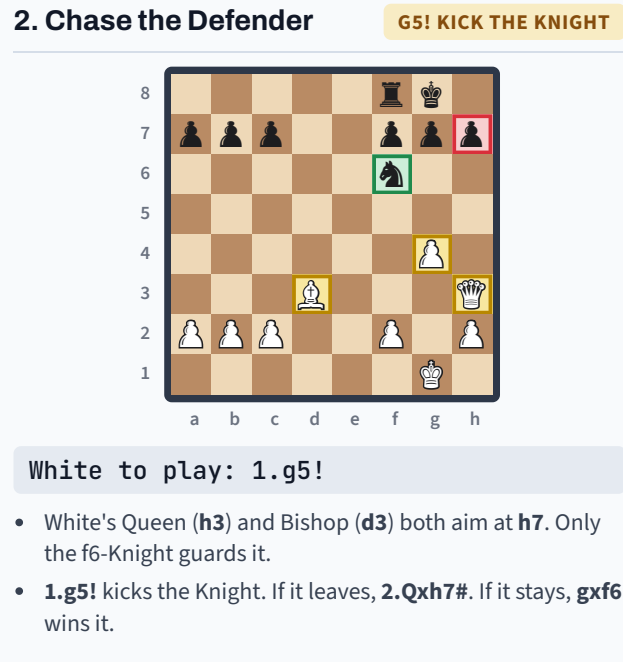


The diagram shows a chessboard with the following pieces: White King on g1, Queen on d1, Rook on a1, Bishop on d5, Knight on f6, Pawns on b2, c2, e2, f2, g2, h2. Black King on g8, Queen on d8, Rook on f6, Knight on e6, Pawns on a7, b7, c7, e7, f7, g7, h7. The Bishop on d5 is highlighted in red, the Knight on f6 in green, and the Rook on f6 in yellow. The squares d5, f6, and g6 are also highlighted in yellow.

White to play: 1.Bxf6! gxf6 2.Rxd5

 - The **d5**-Bishop is attacked by the Rook, but guarded by the **f6**-Knight.
 - **1.Bxf6!** removes the guard. Whatever Black does next, a piece is lost.

G5! KICK THE KNIGHT



2. The Defender

G5! KICK THE KNIGHT

White to play: 1.g5!

- White's Queen (**h3**) and Bishop (**d3**) both aim at **h7**. Only the f6-Knight guards it.
- 1.g5!** kicks the Knight. If it leaves, **2.Qxh7#**. If it stays, **gxf6** wins it.

- ## 2. The Defender
- G5! KICK THE KNIGHT**
-
- White to play: 1.g5!
- White's Queen (**h3**) and Bishop (**d3**) both aim at **h7**. Only the f6-Knight guards it.
 - 1.g5!** kicks the Knight. If it leaves, **2.Qxh7#**. If it stays, **gxf6** wins it.

RXD5! TWO JOBS



3. The Overloaded Defender

RXD5! TWO JOBS

The chessboard shows a position where White has just played Rxd5. Black's knight on f6 is highlighted with a green square, indicating it has two defensive responsibilities: guarding the d5 square (where White's bishop is) and guarding the h7 square (where White's queen is). Other pieces are positioned as follows: White king on e1, queen on g3, rook on c1, pawns on b2, c2, d2, f2, g2, h2; Black king on g8, queen on h8, rook on a8, pawns on a7, b7, c7, d7, e7, f7, g7.

1. Rxd5! Nxd5?? 2. Qxh7#

- The **f6**-Knight has TWO jobs: guard the **d5**-Bishop AND guard **h7**.
- After **1.Rxd5!** it can't do both. Take back and get mated, or stay home a piece down.

- ### 3. The Overloaded Defender
- RXD5! TWO JOBS
-
- The chessboard shows a position where White has played Rxd5. Black's knight on f6 is highlighted with a green square, indicating it has two defensive responsibilities: guarding the d5 square (where White's bishop is) and guarding the h7 square (where White's queen is). Other pieces are positioned as follows: White king on e1, queen on g3, rook on c1, pawns on a2, b2, d2, e2, f2, g2, h2; Black king on g8, queen on h8, rook on a8, pawns on a7, b7, d7, e7, f7, g7, h7.
- 1.Rxd5! Nxd5?? 2.Qxh7#
- The **f6**-Knight has TWO jobs: guard the **d5**-Bishop AND guard **h7**.
 - After **1.Rxd5!** it can't do both. Take back and get mated, or stay home a piece down.

BXF6! + QXH7#



4. Remove the Guard, Mate!

BXF6! + QXH7#

White to play: 1.Bxf6!

- The Queen (**h4**) and Bishop (**c2**) aim at **h7**. **1.Bxf6!** removes its only defender.
- Both **1...gxf6** and **1...Qxf6** lose to **2.Qxh7#**. Any other move gives up the Queen or worse.

- #### 4. Remove the Guard, Mate!
- BXF6! + QXH7#**
-
- White to play: 1.Bxf6!
- The Queen (**h4**) and Bishop (**c2**) aim at **h7**. **1.Bxf6!** removes its only defender.
 - Both **1...gxf6** and **1...Qxf6** lose to **2.Qxh7#**. Any other move gives up the Queen or worse.

Three Ways to Remove a Defender		
Method	How it works	Example on this page
Capture	Trade one of your pieces for the guard	1.Bxf6! (panels 1 & 4)
Chase	Attack the guard (often with a pawn) so it must run away	1.g5! (panel 2)
Overload	Give the guard a second job it can't do at the same time	1.Rxd5! (panel 3)

Three Ways to Remove a Defender		
Method	How it works	Example on this page
Capture	Trade one of your pieces for the guard	1.Bxf6! (panels 1 & 4)
Chase	Attack the guard (often with a pawn) so it must run away	1.g5! (panel 2)
Overload	Give the guard a second job it can't do at the same time	1.Rxd5! (panel 3)

Three Ways to Remove a Defender		
Method	How it works	Example on this page
Capture	Trade one of your pieces for the guard	1.Bxf6! (panels 1 & 4)
Chase	Attack the guard (often with a pawn) so it must run away	1.g5! (panel 2)
Overload	Give the guard a second job it can't do at the same time	1.Rxd5! (panel 3)

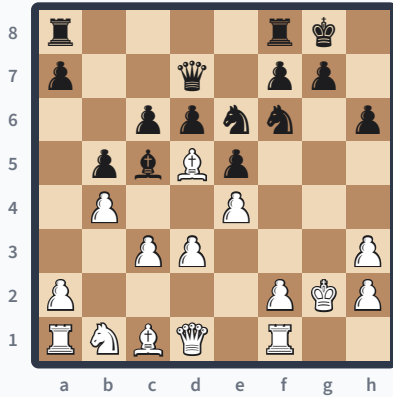
PUZZLES: REMOVE THE DEFENDER

Six positions from real Lichess games

Lesson 8 · Tactics Puzzles

Level 2 Tactical Concepts

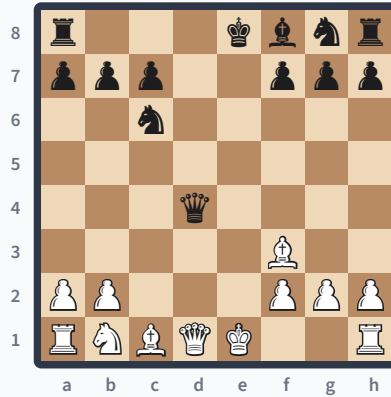
- 1** White to move. Remove the defender and win material!



White (1264) v Black (1315) · 10+0
lichess.org/hXGIlOHC

Answer:

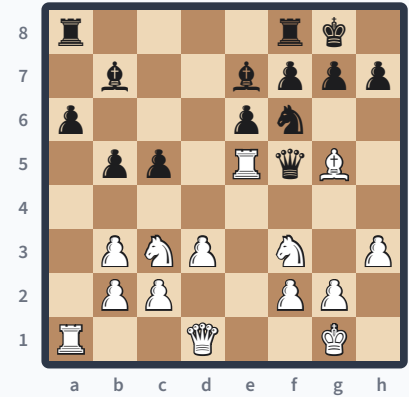
- 2** White to move. Remove the defender and win material!



White (1416) v Black (1330) · 15+15
lichess.org/qpFiMwAQ

Answer:

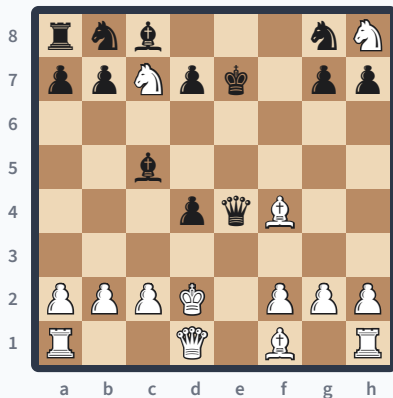
- 3** Black to move. Remove the defender and win material!



White (1821) v Black (2236) · 12+10
lichess.org/M85SkFne

Answer:

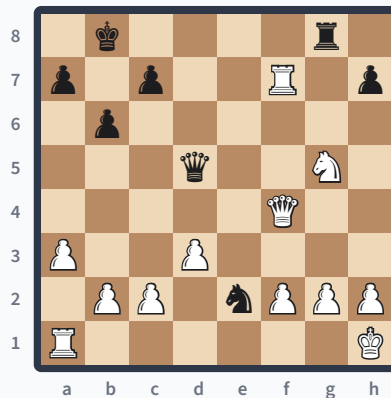
- 4** Black to move. Remove the defender and win material!



White (1077) v Black (1359) · 15+0
lichess.org/8k3DOYsm

Answer:

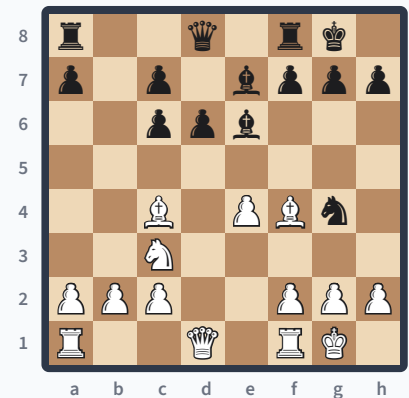
- 5** Black to move. Remove the defender and win material!



White (1853) v Black (1523) · 15+10
lichess.org/UI10BACt

Answer:

- 6** White to move. Remove the defender and win material!



White (2329) v Black (1613) · 10+0
lichess.org/aBqSsQkG

Answer:

Tip: ask "what guards that piece?" Capture, chase or overload the guard first.

Score: ____ / 6

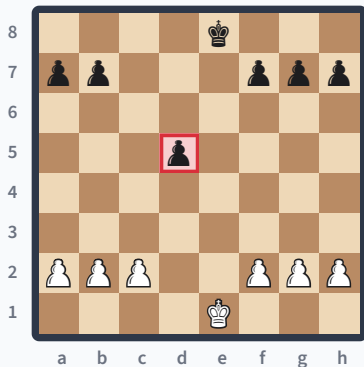
PAWN WEAKNESSES

Islands, doubled and isolated pawns • Count before you trade

Lesson 9 • Strategy
Level 1 Strategy

1. Pawn Islands

FEWER IS BETTER

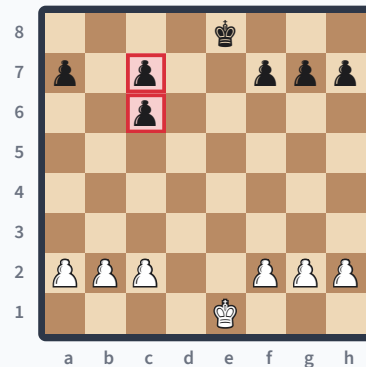


White: 2 islands • Black: 3 islands

- An **island** is a group of pawns standing side by side. An empty file splits them.
- Every island needs its own guard, so **fewer islands = fewer weaknesses**.

2. Doubled Pawns

TWO ON ONE FILE

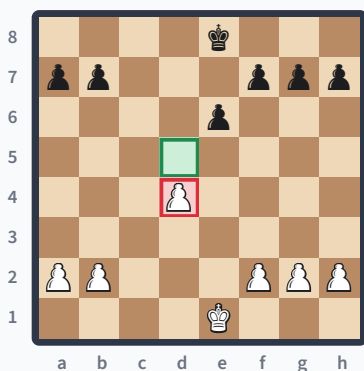


Black's c-pawns are doubled

- Two pawns on one file can't guard each other, and the back one is stuck behind the front one.
- Doubled pawns usually appear after a pawn recapture, such as ...bxc6.

3. The Isolated Pawn

NO NEIGHBOURS

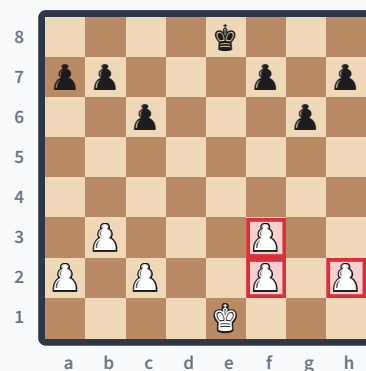


d4 has no pawns on the c- or e-file

- No pawn can ever defend it, so pieces have to guard it instead.
- The square in front (d5, green) is a perfect home for an enemy Knight.

4. Count & Compare

WHO HAS BETTER PAWNS?



White: 3 islands • Black: 2 islands

- White has doubled, isolated f-pawns and a lonely h-pawn. Black's pawns are healthy.
- In an endgame, **better pawns often decide the game**. Compare before you trade pieces!

Pawn Weakness Checklist

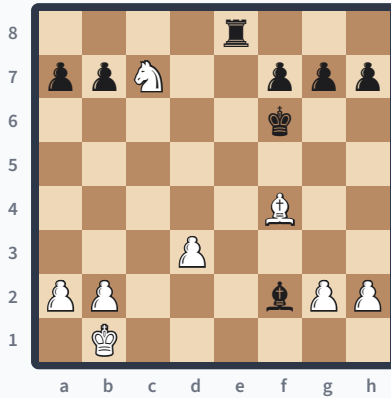
1. **Count the islands** for both sides. Fewer is better.
2. **Look for doubled pawns**, especially after a pawn recapture.
3. **Find isolated pawns**: attack them with pieces, and put a Knight on the square in front.

PUZZLES: SPOT THE WEAKNESS

Six positions from real Lichess games

Lesson 9 · Strategy Puzzles
Level 1 Strategy

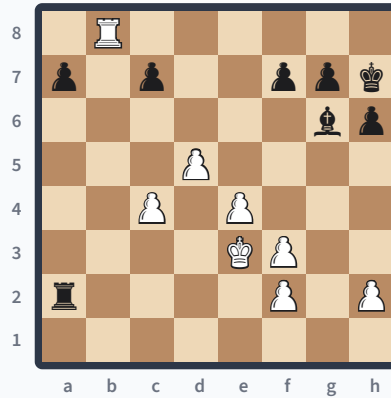
- 1** How many pawn islands does each side have?



White (1259) v Black (1252) · 20+10
lichess.org/WEzpfM95

Answer: _____

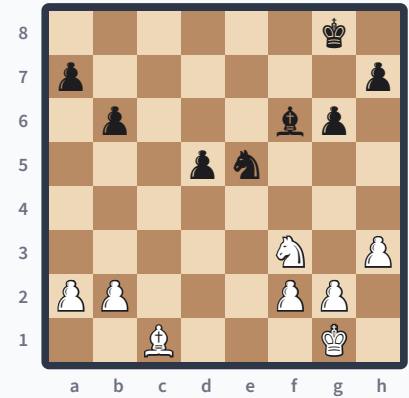
- 2** Which White pawns are doubled?



White (1617) v Black (1575) · 10+0
lichess.org/rXKSU3nF

Answer: _____

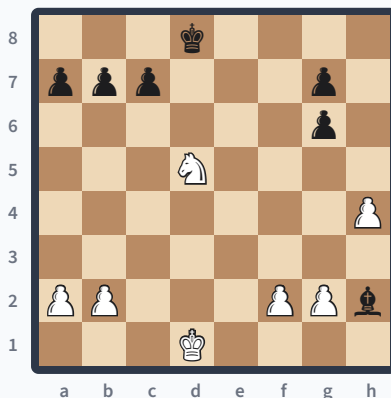
- 3** Find Black's isolated pawn.



White (1715) v Black (1788) · 15+10
lichess.org/ijl17xZq

Answer: _____

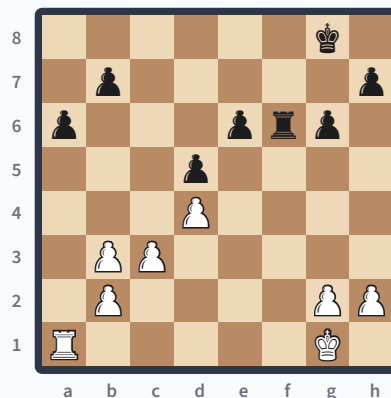
- 4** Find Black's pawns that are doubled AND isolated.



White (1311) v Black (1245) · 10+0
lichess.org/X3eoOOLt

Answer: _____

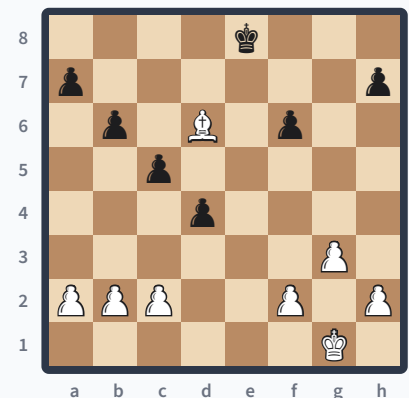
- 5** Where is the base of White's pawn chain?



White (1956) v Black (1715) · 10+0
lichess.org/i9l4d3Sp

Answer: _____

- 6** Name the base and the head of Black's pawn chain.



White (1297) v Black (1319) · 10+0
lichess.org/uptBaJTj

Answer: _____

Tip: count islands file by file, then look for pawns with no neighbours and pawns stacked on one file.

Score: ____ / 6

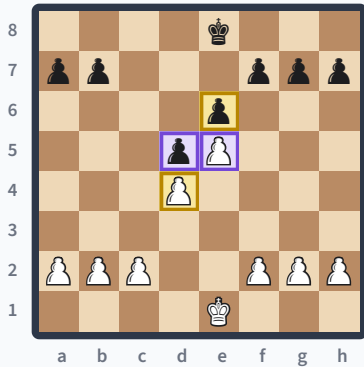
PAWN CHAINS & CAPTURES

Head and base of the chain • Which pawn should take?

Lesson 10 • Strategy
Level 1 Strategy

1. The Pawn Chain

PAWNS GUARD DIAGONALLY

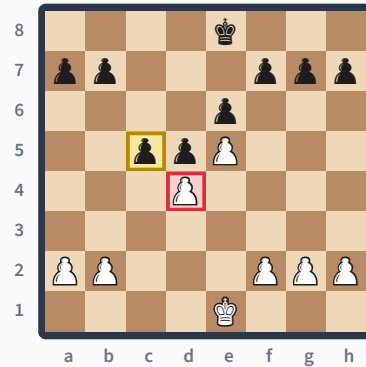


White: d4-e5 • Black: e6-d5

- Each pawn guards the one in front. Only the **base** (yellow) has no pawn guarding it.
- The chain points where to attack: White's **e5** head points at the kingside.

2. Attack the Base

HIT IT AT THE BOTTOM

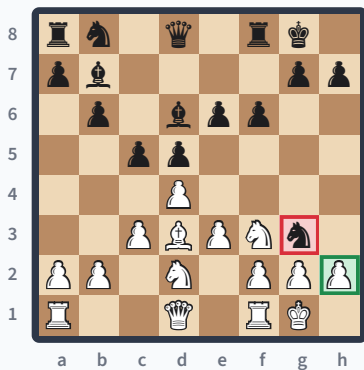


Black plays ...c5! hitting d4

- Attack a chain at its **base**. If the base falls, the pawns above it are loose.
- This is Black's plan in the French: ...c5, and later ...f6 for the head.

3. Capture Toward the Centre

REAL GAME: HXG3!



White to move: hxg3! (not fxg3)

- After **hxg3** White keeps 1 pawn island. After **fxg3** there would be 2.
- Rule of thumb: **take toward the centre**. (White 1826 v Black 2228, lichess.org/UV5MVDWH)

4. Don't Make Weak Pawns

REAL GAME: DXC6!



Black to move: dxc6! (not bxc6)

- After **bxc6** the a6-pawn is isolated. After **dxc6** the c-pawns are doubled, but every pawn has a neighbour and the d-file opens.
- Here, avoiding a weak pawn beats the rule of thumb. (White 1449 v Black 1597, lichess.org/8uZRNw8n)

Which Pawn Should Take?

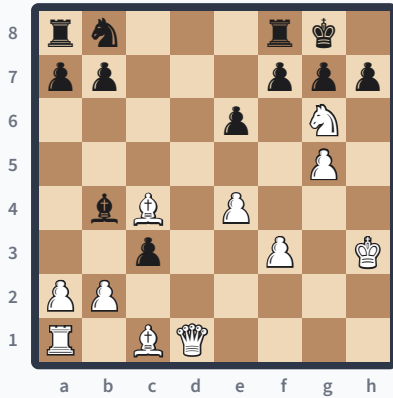
1. **List both captures**, then picture the pawns after each one.
2. **Count islands** and look for new doubled or isolated pawns. Pick the healthier structure.
3. **If it's close, take toward the centre**. Always check tactics first: a capture that loses a piece is never right!

PUZZLES: WHICH PAWN TAKES?

Six positions from real Lichess games

Lesson 10 · Strategy Puzzles
Level 1 Strategy

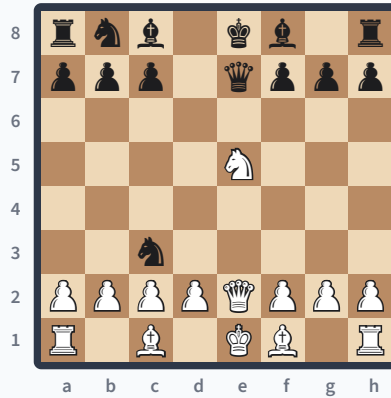
- 1** Black to move. Which pawn should capture on g6?



White (2156) v Black (1725) · 15+15
lichess.org/LlwhmVao

Answer: _____

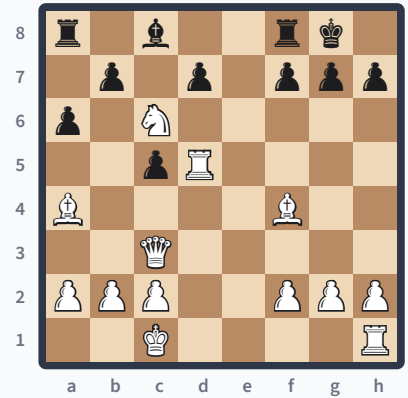
- 2** White to move. Which pawn should capture on c3?



White (1851) v Black (1585) · 10+0
lichess.org/gNXbeLEV

Answer: _____

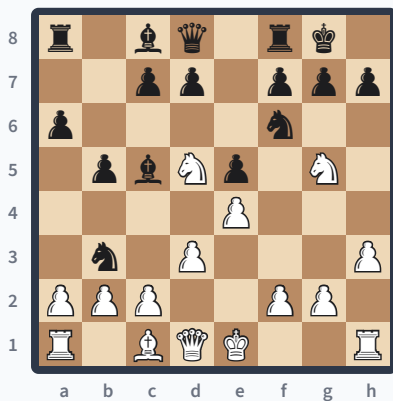
- 3** Black to move. Which pawn should capture on c6?



White (1322) v Black (1340) · 12+0
lichess.org/FSDktJlR

Answer: _____

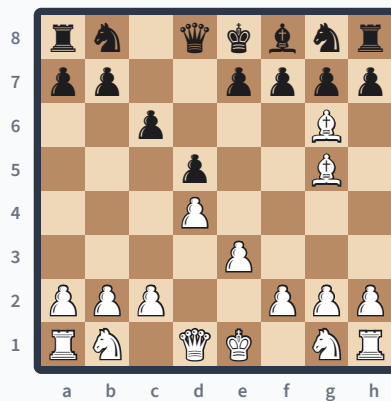
- 4** White to move. Which pawn should capture on b3?



White (1697) v Black (1660) · 30+0
lichess.org/Wutupk7w

Answer: _____

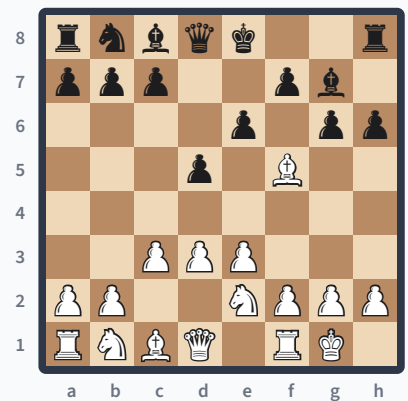
- 5** Black to move. Which pawn should capture on g6?



White (1760) v Black (1683) · 15+6
lichess.org/6UwhypzJ

Answer: _____

- 6** Black to move. Which pawn should capture on f5?



White (1297) v Black (1655) · 7+9
lichess.org/OkvFM9sn

Answer: _____

Tip: picture the pawns after each capture. Fewer islands and no lonely pawns wins; if it's close, take toward the centre.

Score: ____ / 6

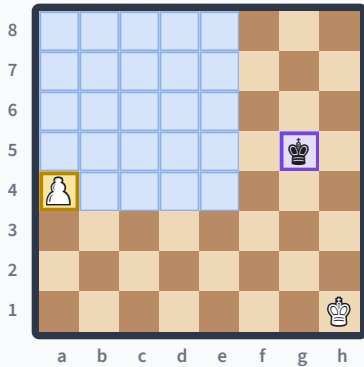
HOW TO PROMOTE

King + Pawn vs. King • The attacker's guide

Lesson 11 • Endgame
Level 1 Endgame Concepts

1. The Rule of the Square

OUTSIDE = PAWN RUNS

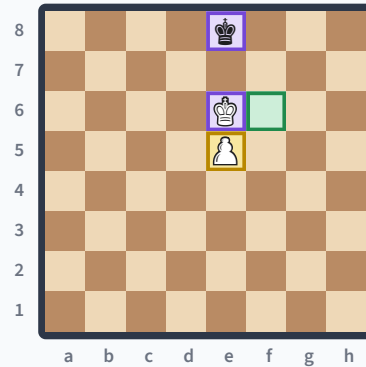


Black to move: 1...Kf6 2.a5 → a8=Q

- Draw a box from the pawn to its promotion rank (blue). Can the enemy King step inside it?
- No: the **g5**-King is too far away, so just run! Your own King isn't even needed.

2. King in Front of the Pawn

KING ON 6TH = WIN

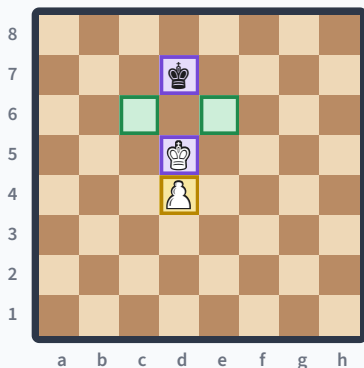


1.Kf6! Kf8 2.e6 Ke8 3.e7 Kd7 4.Kf7

- **The King leads, the pawn follows.** White's King on **e6** clears the way for the pawn.
- King on the 6th, in front of its pawn, wins *whoever is to move*. Then 5.e8=Q.

3. Push the King Away

THE OPPOSITION

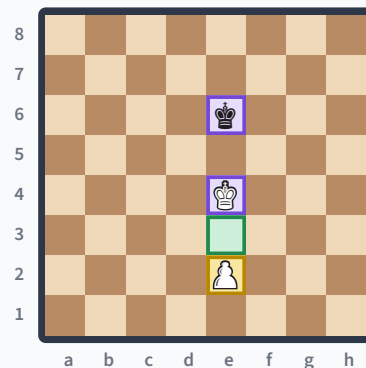


Black to move: 1...Ke7 2.Kc6! (or 1...Kc7 2.Ke6!)

- Kings face each other with one square between. The side that must move has to **give way**.
- Black steps aside, so White steps the *other* way (the "shoulder") and marches up the board.

4. The Spare Pawn Move

1.E3! PASS THE MOVE



White to move: 1.e3!

- White is to move, so Black has the opposition. No problem: **1.e3!** is a "waiting move".
- Now Black must give way. **Keep your pawn back** so you have spare moves in hand.

The Promotion Recipe

1. **Check the square:** if the enemy King can't get inside it, push the pawn and don't look back.
2. **King first:** march your King in front of the pawn. The goal is the 6th rank (3rd for Black), two squares ahead of the pawn.
3. **Win the opposition:** face the enemy King with one square between, with THEM to move. A spare pawn move can hand them the move.

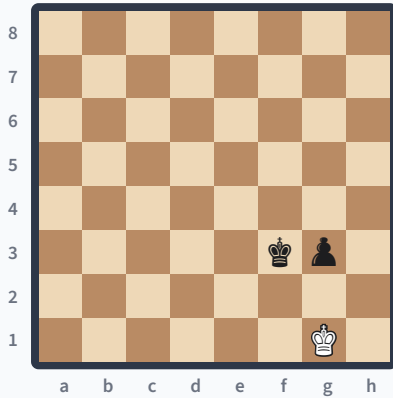
PUZZLES: PROMOTE THE PAWN

Six positions from real Lichess games

Lesson 11 · Endgame Puzzles

Level 1 Endgame Concepts

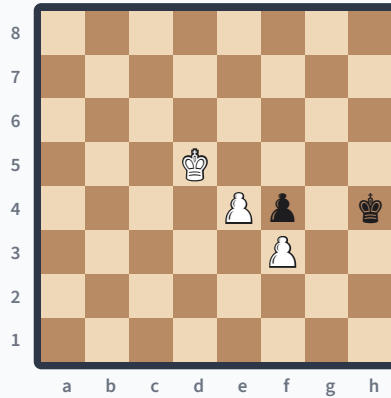
- 1** Black to move and win. Only one move works!



White (1705) v Black (1679) · 10+0
lichess.org/pzfKnCUe

Answer: _____

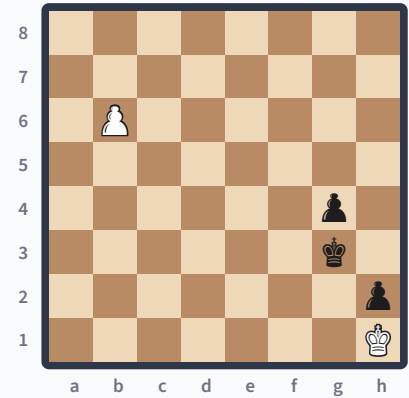
- 2** White to move and win. Only one move works!



White (1631) v Black (1537) · 5+5
lichess.org/4u0MUqHf

Answer: _____

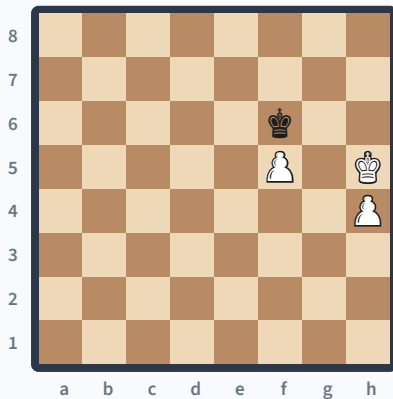
- 3** Black to move and win. Only one move works!



White (1538) v Black (1529) · 7+5
lichess.org/YIXZMuXV

Answer: _____

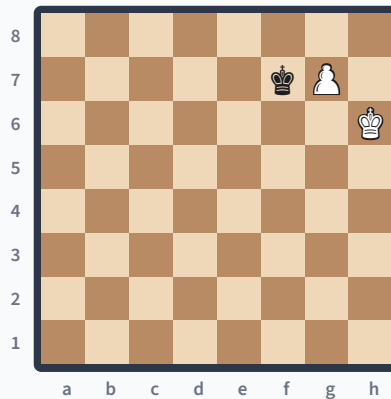
- 4** White to move and win. Only one move works!



White (1661) v Black (1762) · 19+17
lichess.org/WVsn7wDi

Answer: _____

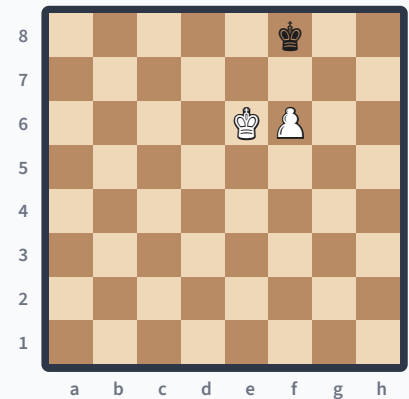
- 5** White to move and win. Only one move works!



White (1514) v Black (1425) · 15+0
lichess.org/UvX0bacP

Answer: _____

- 6** White to move and win. Only one move works!



White (1773) v Black (1613) · 10+0
lichess.org/Xp4npQfv

Answer: _____

Tip: King in front of the pawn, take the opposition, and count the squares.

Score: ____ / 6

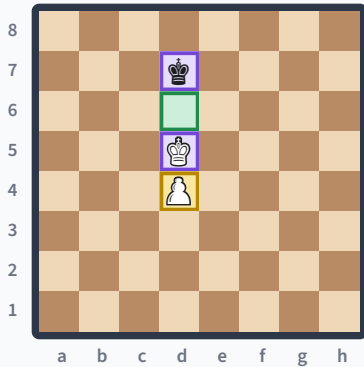
HOW TO GET STALEMATED

King vs. King + Pawn • The defender's guide

Lesson 12 • Endgame
Level 1 Endgame Concepts

1. Get in Front of the Pawn

BLOCK THE ROAD

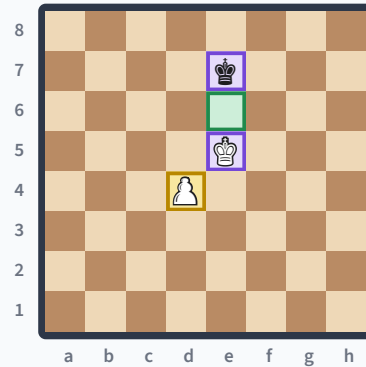


White to move: draw

- Black's King stands **in front of the pawn**, on its road to d8. That's the first job.
- White is to move, so Black has the opposition. Same position with Black to move? White wins (see page 21).

2. Mirror the King

1...KE7! KEEP OPPOSITION

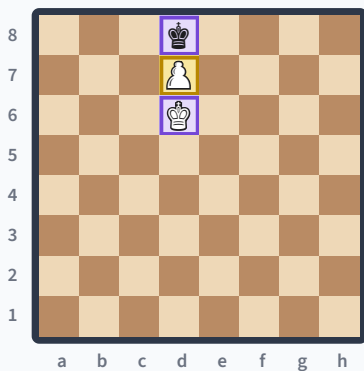


1.Ke5 Ke7! 2.d5 Kd7 3.d6 Kd8!

- When the King steps to **e5**, copy it: **1...Ke7!** Facing it keeps the opposition.
- When the pawn pushes, step **straight back** (3...Kd8!). 1...Kd8? or 3...Kc8? would lose.

3. The Happy Ending

STALEMATE = DRAW

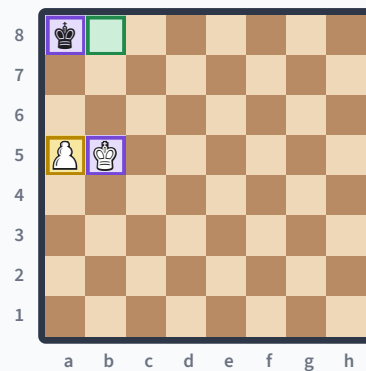


4.Ke6 Ke8! 5.d7+ Kd8 6.Kd6 ½-½

- Black takes the opposition once more with **4...Ke8!** and White runs out of tricks.
- Black is not in check but has no legal move: **stalemate**. The game is a draw!

4. Bonus: The Rook Pawn

CORNER = DRAW



White to move: draw

- With an **a-** or **h-**pawn, the defender just needs to reach the corner in front of it.
- White can't push the King away (there's no "other side"), so the defender just shuffles in the corner. Draw!

Win or Draw? Quick Guide

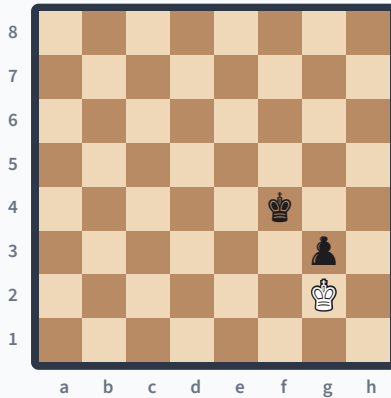
Position	Result
Defending King can't get inside the square	Pawn promotes: win
Attacking King on the 6th, in front of its pawn	Win, whoever moves
Defending King in front of the pawn, and keeps the opposition	Draw (stalemate)
Rook pawn, defending King reaches the corner	Always a draw

PUZZLES: HOLD THE DRAW

Six positions from real Lichess games

Lesson 12 · Endgame Puzzles
Level 1 Endgame Concepts

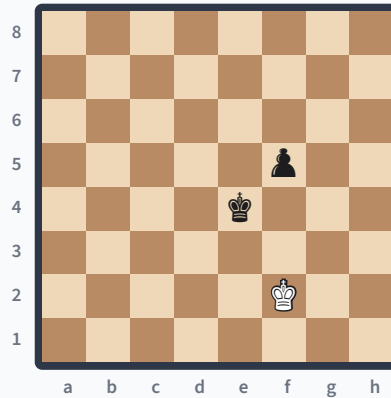
- 1 White to move. Find the only move that draws!



White (2165) v Black (2158) · 8+0
lichess.org/Aj0AOyg9

Answer: _____

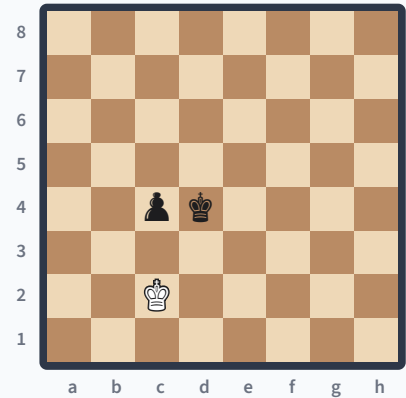
- 2 White to move. Find the only move that draws!



White (2274) v Black (2191) · 10+0
lichess.org/EoMOMVGc

Answer: _____

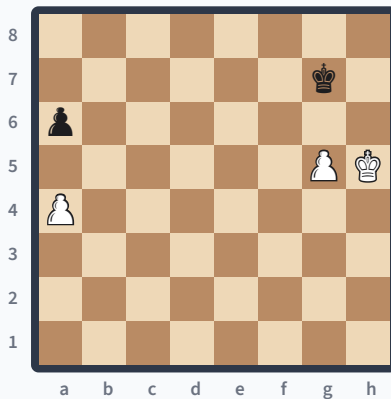
- 3 White to move. Find the only move that draws!



White (1426) v Black (1481) · 10+0
lichess.org/pzXBbYB4

Answer: _____

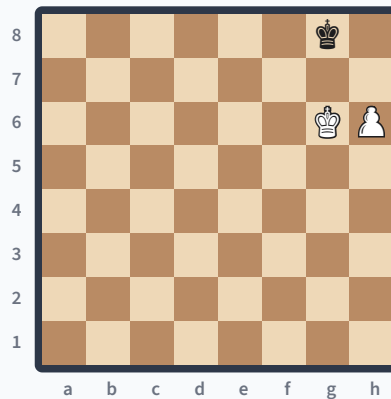
- 4 Black to move. Find the only move that draws!



White (1891) v Black (1607) · 5+5
lichess.org/Qv9WBOoF

Answer: _____

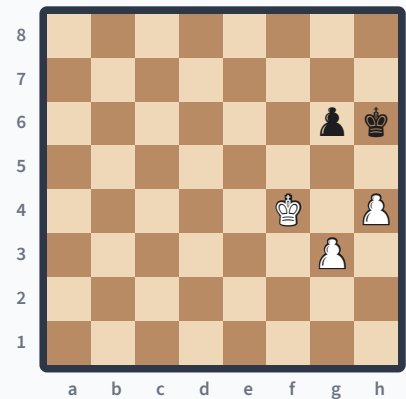
- 5 Black to move. Find the only move that draws!



White (1371) v Black (1223) · 10+0
lichess.org/svUXpgsE

Answer: _____

- 6 Black to move. Find the only move that draws!



White (1686) v Black (1747) · 7+2
lichess.org/pylapHm1

Answer: _____

Tip: get in front of the pawn and keep the opposition. Rook pawns are the easiest draws.

Score: ____ / 6

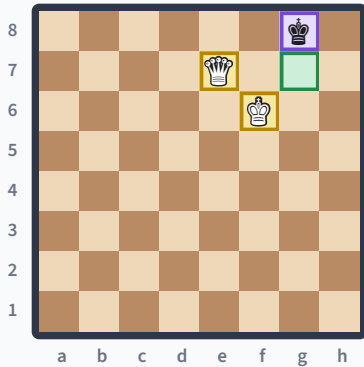
BASIC CHECKMATES

The mates every player must know • Push the King to the edge

Lesson 13 • Basics
Level 1 Checkmating Patterns

1. The Kiss of Death

QG7# FACE TO FACE

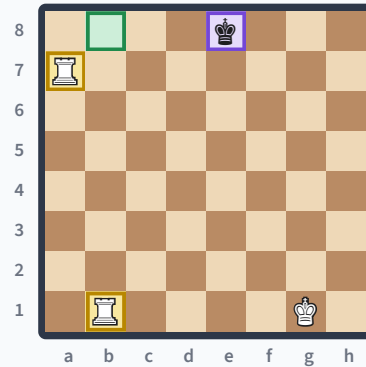


White to play: 1.Qg7#

- The Queen goes **right next to** the enemy King, protected by its own King on f6.
- The King can't capture a protected Queen, and she covers every escape square.

2. The Ladder Mate

RB8# TWO ROOKS

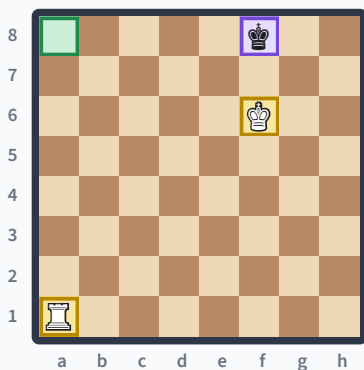


White to play: 1.Rb8#

- One Rook guards a rank (a7 blocks the 7th), the other gives check on the next one. Climb like a ladder!
- Keep the Rooks **far away** from the King so it can't attack them. No need for your own King.

3. King + Rook vs. King

RA8# KINGS FACE OFF

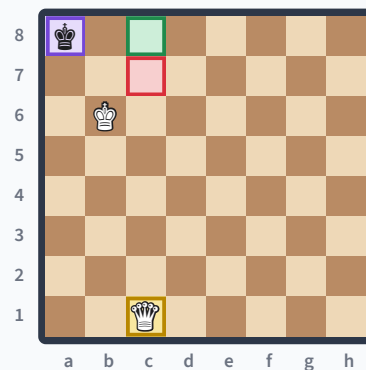


White to play: 1.Ra8#

- With one Rook you need your King. Kings **face each other** (f6 vs f8), then the Rook checks along the edge.
- The King blocks e7, f7, g7; the Rook covers the whole back rank.

4. Watch Out: Stalemate!

QC7?? NO MOVES = DRAW



1.Qc7?? stalemate. 1.Qc8# wins!

- After 1.Qc7?? Black isn't in check but has no legal move. A won game becomes a draw!
- A Queen a **knight's jump** away from a cornered King is the classic stalemate trap.

The Checkmate Recipe

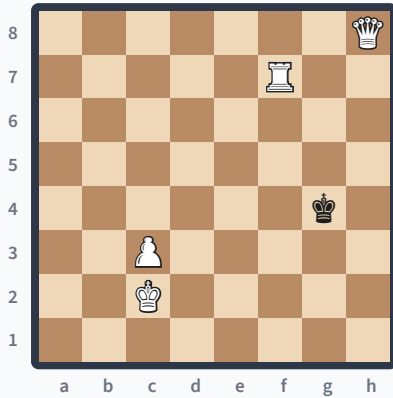
1. **Edge first:** almost every mate happens on the edge of the board. Build a "box" and shrink it.
2. **Bring the King:** with one Queen or one Rook, your own King must come and help.
3. **Before every move, count Black's moves:** if the King has zero moves and is NOT in check, it's stalemate. Leave it one square!

PUZZLES: BASIC CHECKMATES

Six positions from real Lichess games

Lesson 13 · Basics Puzzles
Level 1 Checkmating Patterns

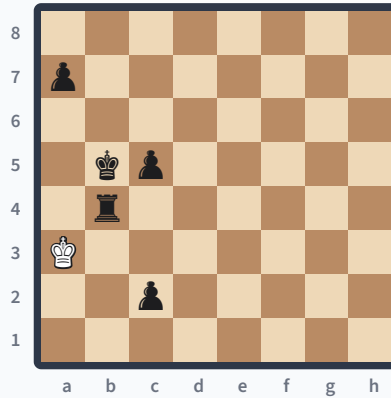
1 White to move. Checkmate in 2!



White (1791) v Black (1380) · 10+0
lichess.org/5mKbvFmB

Answer: _____

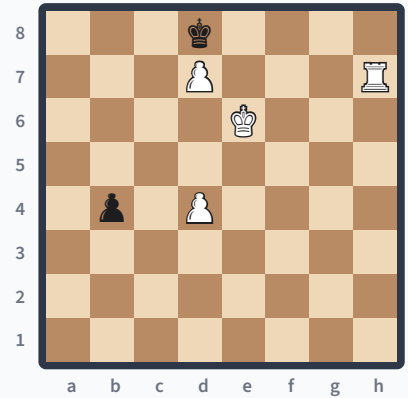
2 Black to move. Checkmate in 2! Don't stalemate!



White (1728) v Black (1754) · 10+0
lichess.org/mrPVg1Hq

Answer: _____

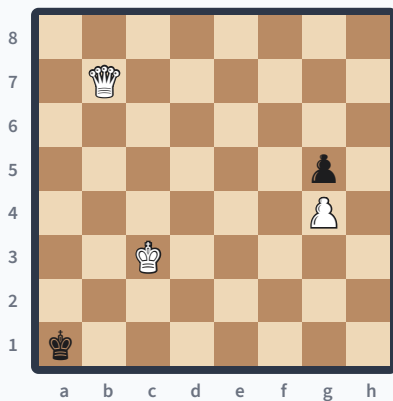
3 White to move. Checkmate in 2!



White (1993) v Black (1615) · 10+0
lichess.org/dnKLHC9g

Answer: _____

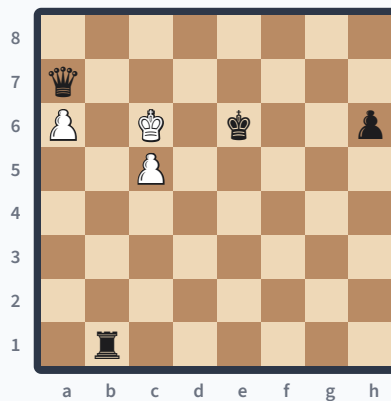
4 White to move. Checkmate in 1! Don't stalemate!



White (1296) v Black (1315) · 10+0
lichess.org/PAansThU

Answer: _____

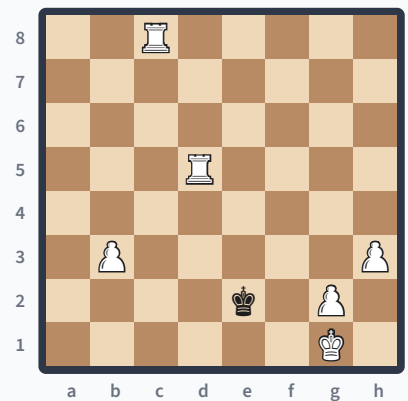
5 Black to move. Checkmate in 1! Don't stalemate!



White (1451) v Black (1409) · 10+0
lichess.org/IWkvJkvw

Answer: _____

6 White to move. Checkmate in 1!



White (1203) v Black (970) · 10+2
lichess.org/tBXOrjIo

Answer: _____

Tip: mate happens on the edge. Before a quiet move, check the King still has a move!

Score: ____ / 6

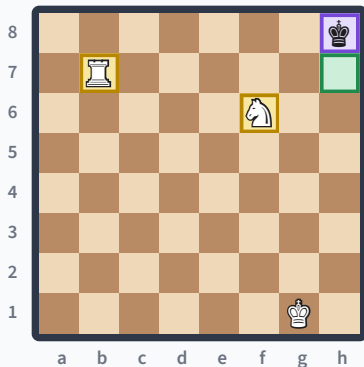
FAMOUS MATING PATTERNS

Mates with names • Learn the picture, find it in your games

Lesson 14 • Attack
Level 1 Checkmating Patterns

1. The Arabian Mate

ROOK + KNIGHT

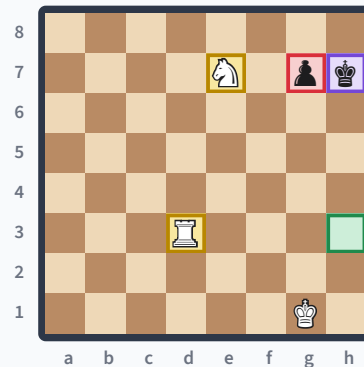


White to play: 1.Rh7#

- The King is in the corner. The Rook checks from **h7**, right next to it.
- The Knight on **f6** does two jobs: it protects the Rook AND covers **g8**. One of the oldest mates known!

2. Anastasia's Mate

KNIGHT + ROOK ON EDGE

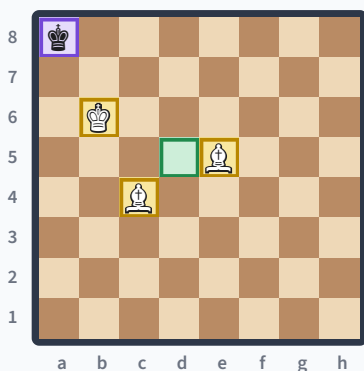


White to play: 1.Rh3#

- The Knight on **e7** covers **g6** and **g8**; Black's own **g7**-pawn blocks the last square.
- The Rook swings to the **h**-file with check. The King is trapped on the edge.

3. Two Bishops Mate

BD5# SIDE BY SIDE

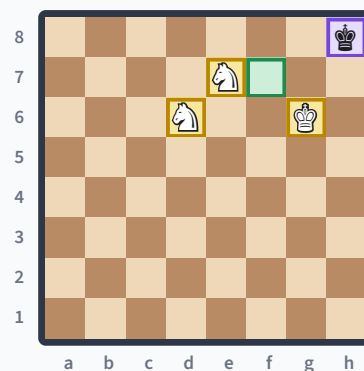


White to play: 1.Bd5#

- One Bishop checks on the long diagonal (**d5**), the other guards **b8** from **e5**.
- The King on **b6** covers a7 and b7. The Bishops work best side by side, like a wall.

4. Two Knights Mate

Nf7# ONLY IF THEY BLUNDER



White to play: 1.Nf7#

- **e7**-Knight guards g8, the King guards g7/h7, and **Nf7** gives check. Mate!
- But two Knights **can't force** mate on a lone King. This only happens if the defender walks into it.

Pattern Cheat Sheet

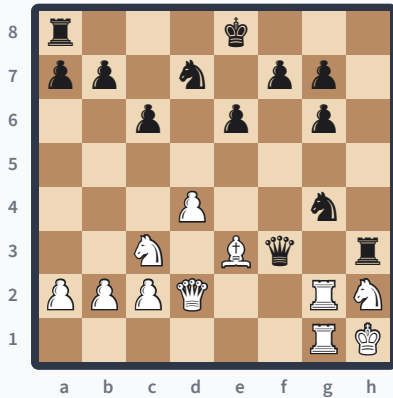
Pattern	Pieces	Look for...
Arabian	Rook + Knight	A King in the corner; Knight two squares diagonally away from it
Anastasia	Knight + Rook (or Queen)	A King on the edge, boxed in by its own pawn and a Knight on e7
Two Bishops	B + B + King	Drive the King to a corner; Bishops side by side make a wall
Two Knights	N + N + King	Not forced vs. a lone King: a trap to set, not a plan to count on

PUZZLES: NAMED MATES

Six positions from real Lichess games

Lesson 14 · Attack Puzzles
Level 1 Checkmating Patterns

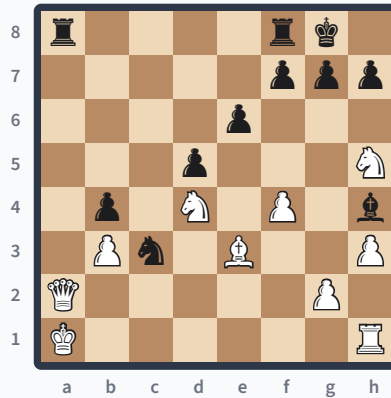
- 1** Black to move. Checkmate in 1. Name the pattern!



White (1392) v Black (1549) · 10+8
lichess.org/GThi2Edw

Answer: _____

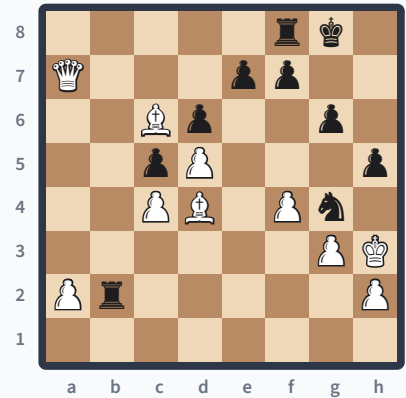
- 2** Black to move. Checkmate in 1. Name the pattern!



White (1696) v Black (1812) · 10+0
lichess.org/ilqPjRcT

Answer: _____

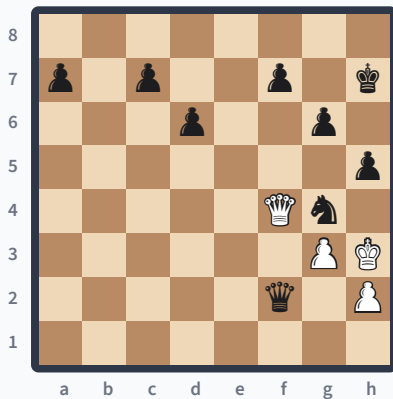
- 3** Black to move. Checkmate in 1. Name the pattern!



White (1403) v Black (1887) · 10+0
lichess.org/HpKRLXrA

Answer: _____

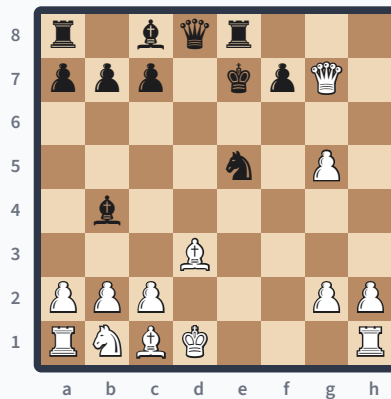
- 4** Black to move. Checkmate in 1. Name the pattern!



White (1688) v Black (1935) · 15+1
lichess.org/iKT0TtWr

Answer: _____

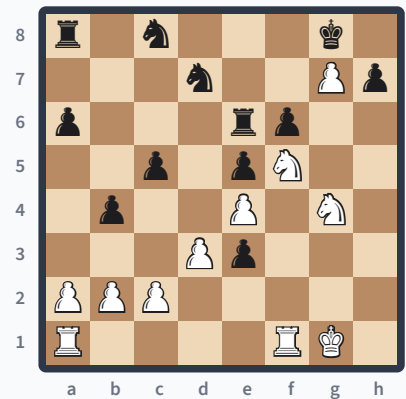
- 5** Black to move. Checkmate in 1. Name the pattern!



White (1438) v Black (1467) · 3+8
lichess.org/sxjj9iMf

Answer: _____

- 6** White to move. Checkmate in 1. Name the pattern!



White (1679) v Black (1690) · 10+0
lichess.org/eK91lvjo

Answer: _____

Tip: Knights love the Arabian and Anastasia mates. Learn the pictures!

Score: ____ / 6

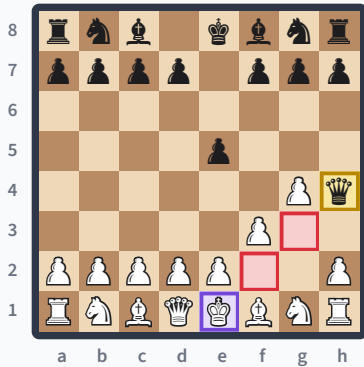
FOOL'S MATE & THE SHILLING

Two famous traps • Know the bait, dodge the hook

Lesson 15 • Attack
Level 1 Opening Traps

1. Fool's Mate

MATE IN TWO MOVES



1. f3? e5 2. g4?? Qh4#

- White pushed the f- and g-pawns and opened the diagonal from h4 to the King.
- Rule: in the opening, **leave the f- and g-pawns alone**. It even happens in real games!

2. The Shilling Bait

3...Nd4!? LEAVES E5

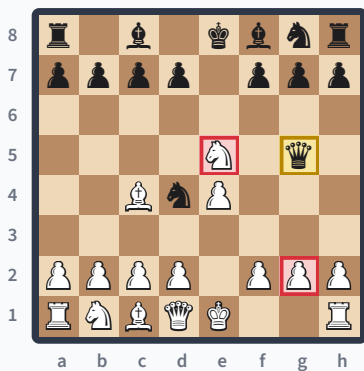


1. e4 e5 2. Nf3 Nc6 3. Bc4 Nd4!?

- Black leaves **e5** hanging. It looks like a free pawn for White's Knight.
- Calm moves win for White: **4.Nxd4** or **4.O-O**. Don't grab the pawn!

3. Taking the Bait

4.NXE5? QG5!



4. Nxe5? Qg5! 5. Nxf7?? Qxg2 6. Rf1

- The Queen attacks the Knight on **e5** AND the pawn on **g2**.
- 5. Nxf7?? forks Queen and Rook, but it is far too slow. Better: **5.Bxf7+** or **5.O-O**.

4. Smothered Mate

6...Qxe4+ 7.BE2 NF3#



6... Qxe4+ 7. Be2 Nf3#

- White's own pieces box the King in. The Knight mates: a **smothered mate**.
- Blackburne is said to have won a shilling a game with this trap. That's where the name comes from.

How Traps Work

1. **The bait:** something looks free, like a pawn or a piece.
2. **The greed:** the opponent grabs it without checking why it was left.
3. **The punishment:** a fork, a mate or a lost Queen. Before you take anything free, ask **"Why did they leave it?"**

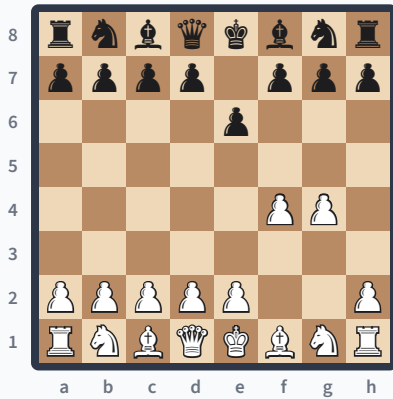
PUZZLES: FOOL'S MATE & SHILLING

Six positions from real Lichess games

Lesson 15 · Attack Puzzles

Level 1 Opening Traps

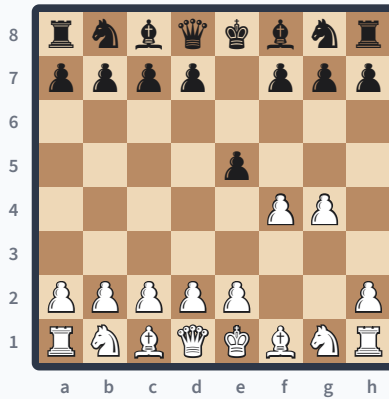
- 1** Black to move. White made the Fool's Mate mistake. Punish it!



White (1533) v Black (1897) · 10+0
lichess.org/V7a3QloB

Answer: _____

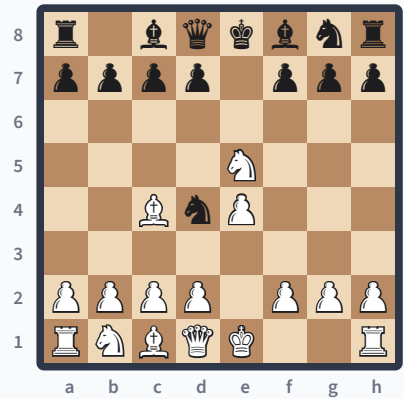
- 2** Black to move. Black played ...Bc5 here. What did Black miss?



White (946) v Black (1545) · 19+0
lichess.org/hyHDCD1r

Answer: _____

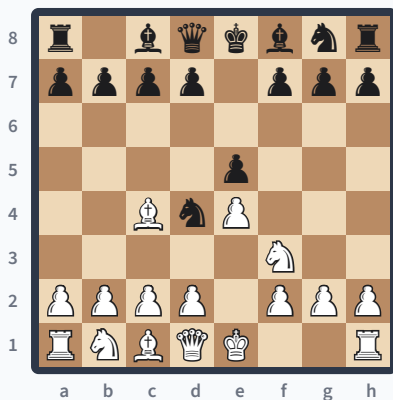
- 3** Black to move. White just took on e5. Spring the trap!



White (1562) v Black (1556) · 5+8
lichess.org/ScIT6CAQ

Answer: _____

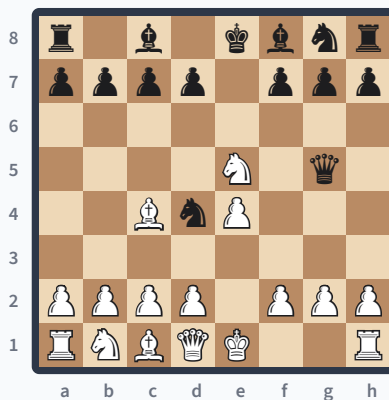
- 4** White to move. Black played ...Nd4. Should White take on e5?



White (1862) v Black (1556) · 10+0
lichess.org/SCBFMr9d

Answer: _____

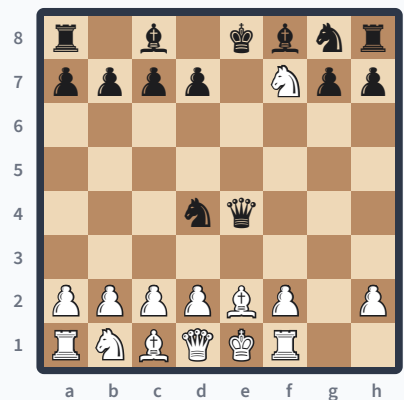
- 5** White to move. Black's Queen hits e5 and g2. What now?



White (1689) v Black (1677) · 30+0
lichess.org/NTkSmCQ8

Answer: _____

- 6** Black to move. Finish the trap!



White (1446) v Black (1505) · 15+0
lichess.org/i070jbuW

Answer: _____

Tip: know the pattern: after f3/f4 and g4, the diagonal h4–e1 is open; after ...Nd4, e5 is bait.

Score: ____ / 6

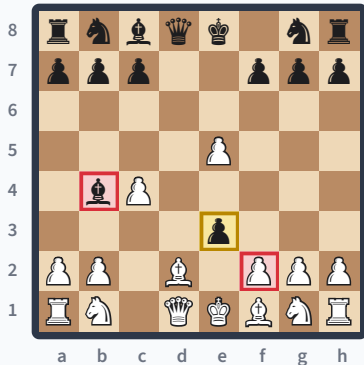
LASKER TRAP & FISHING POLE

A Knight promotion and a Rook on the h-file

Lesson 16 · Attack
Level 1 Opening Traps

1. The Albin Counter-Gambit

4.E3? DXE3!

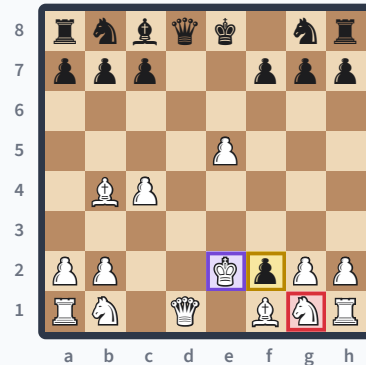


1.d4 d5 2.c4 e5 3.dxe5 d4 4.e3? Bb4+
5.Bd2 dxe3!

- Black's d-pawn charges forward. 4.e3? looks natural, but it opens a door.
- Now **6.fxe3!** is the only safe move, and the game is equal.

2. The Trap Springs

6.Bxb4?? EXF2+

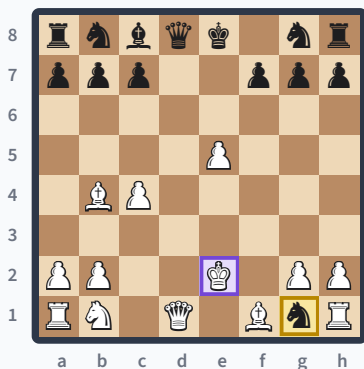


6.Bxb4?? exf2+ 7.Ke2

- White grabs the Bishop. But the pawn on **f2** gives check and attacks **g1**.
- Now comes the surprise that gives this trap its name...

3. Promote to a Knight!

7...FXG1=N+!

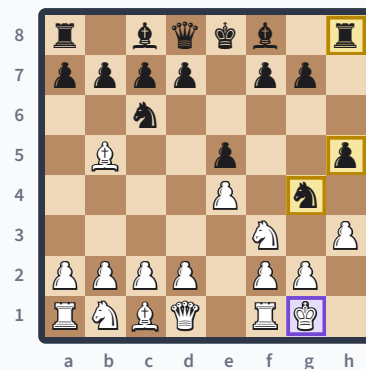


7...fxg1=N+! 8.Ke1 Qh4+

- A new Queen on g1 could be taken. A **Knight gives check**, so White has no time.
- 8.Rxg1 walks into **Bg4+**, a skewer that wins the Queen on d1.

4. The Fishing Pole

BAIT ON G4



4...Ng4 5.h3 h5! 6.hxg4?? hxg4

- Taking the Knight opens the **h-file** for the Rook on h8. After 7.Ne1 Qh4 Black mates in 3.
- Don't bite: **6.c3** or **6.d4**, and the Knight on g4 is just in the way.

Trap Spotter's Checklist

1. **Something offered near your King?** Picture the lines that open if you take it.
2. **A pawn charging at your King?** Check every check it could give, and every square it attacks.
3. **Promotion is not always a Queen:** a Knight can give check (and fork) when a Queen can't.

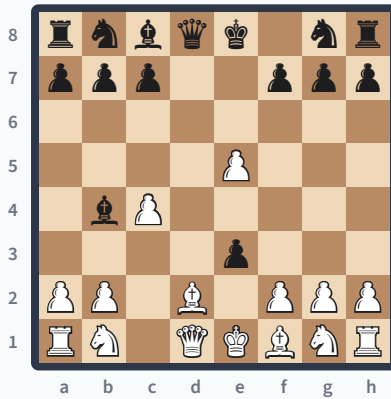
PUZZLES: LASKER & FISHING POLE

Six positions from real Lichess games

Lesson 16 · Attack Puzzles

Level 1 Opening Traps

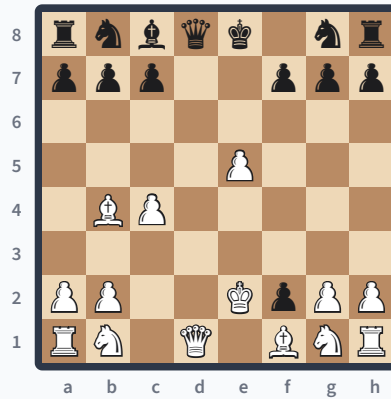
- 1** White to move. Avoid the Lasker Trap!



White (1610) v Black (1606) · 10+0
lichess.org/UzKImTR3

Answer:

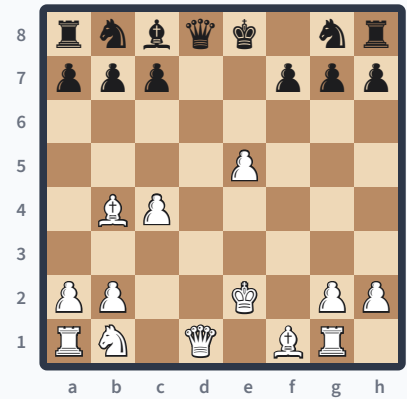
- 2** Black to move. Find the killer promotion!



Example line (not from a game)

Answer:

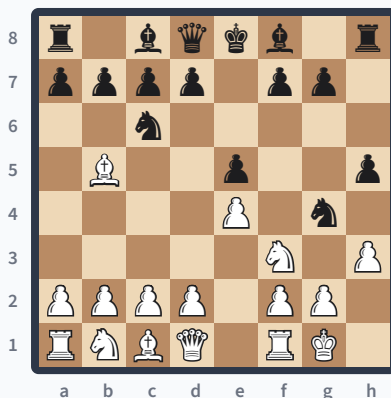
- 3** Black to move. White took the new Knight. Win the Queen!



Example line (not from a game)

Answer:

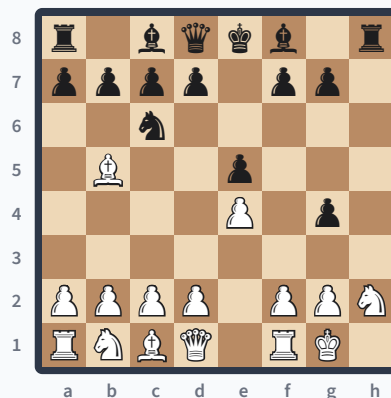
- 4** White to move. Should White take the Knight on g4?



White (1500) v Black (1906) · 30+0
lichess.org/oBesEOOT

Answer:

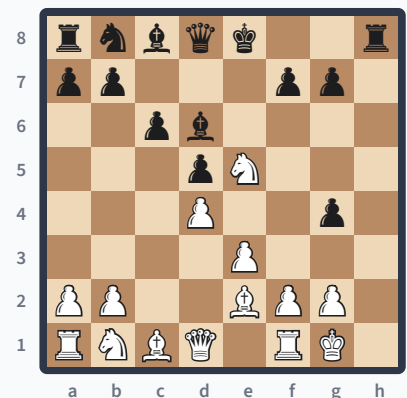
- 5** Black to move. The h-file is open. Attack!



White (1265) v Black (1625) · 10+15
lichess.org/JXe8i39M

Answer:

- 6** Black to move. Mate in 3!



White (1928) v Black (2050) · 10+5
lichess.org/q9cxuwVA

Answer:

Tip: when a pawn races toward your King, count its checks; when a piece is offered near your King, count the lines that open.

Score: ____ / 6

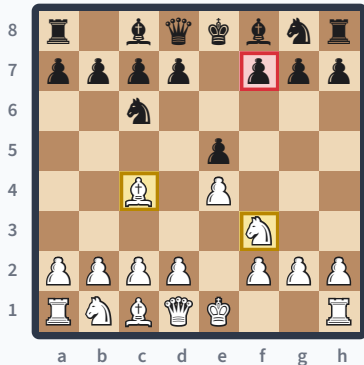
THE ITALIAN GAME

1.e4 e5 2.Nf3 Nc6 3.Bc4 • Aim at f7, build the centre

Lesson 17 • Openings
Level 1 Opening Plans

1. The First Moves

3.BC4 EYES F7

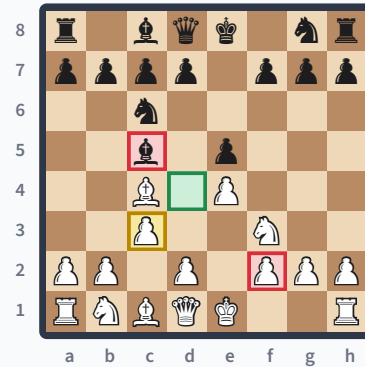


1.e4 e5 2.Nf3 Nc6 3.Bc4

- **2.Nf3** attacks e5 and develops. **3.Bc4** points the Bishop at Black's weak spot, **f7**.
- Two pieces out and the kingside is clear: White can castle next move.

2. Giuoco Piano: Prepare d4

4.C3! THE KEY MOVE



3... Bc5 4.c3!

- Black copies with **3...Bc5**, aiming at **f2**. ("Giuoco Piano" means "quiet game".)
- **4.c3!** gets ready for **d4**: when Black takes on d4, White takes back with a pawn.

3. Plan A: The Big Centre

E4 + D4 PAWNS

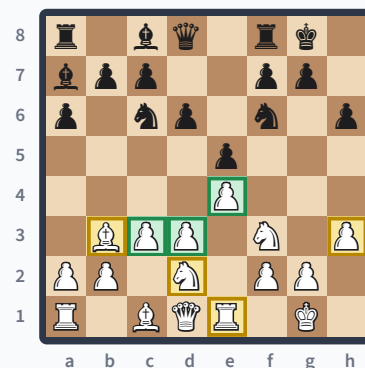


4... Nf6 5.d4 exd4 6.cxd4 Bb4+ 7.Bd2

- White now has two pawns side by side on **e4** and **d4**: the dream centre!
- Block the check with a piece (7.Bd2) and keep developing. Black will try to hit the centre with ...d5.

4. Plan B: The Slow Build

TARGET SETUP



5.d3 d6 6.0-0 0-0 7.Re1 a6 8.Bb3 Ba7 9.h3 h6 10.Nbd2

- Castle, **Re1** behind the e-pawn, **Bb3** keeps the Bishop safe, **h3** stops ...Bg4.
- Next: **Nf1-g3**, THEN strike with **d4**.

What White Wants in the Italian

1. **The centre:** c3 then d4, to get pawns on both e4 and d4.
2. **Fast, safe King:** Knight, Bishop, castle by move 5 or 6, then a Rook to e1.
3. **The f7 pressure:** keep the Bishop on the a2–g8 diagonal (c4, or b3 when it's attacked). Tricks like the Fried Liver live here.

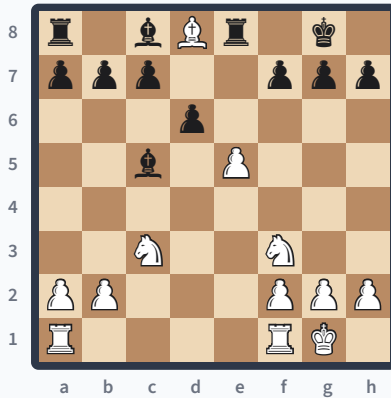
PUZZLES: ITALIAN GAME

Six positions from real Lichess games

Lesson 17 · Openings Puzzles

Level 1 Opening Plans

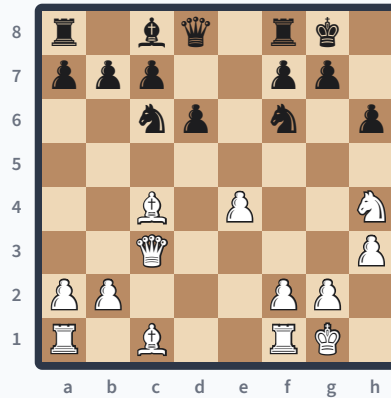
1 Black to move. Punish the mistake!



White (1955) v Black (1890) · 10+0
lichess.org/VOeOmP1j

Answer:

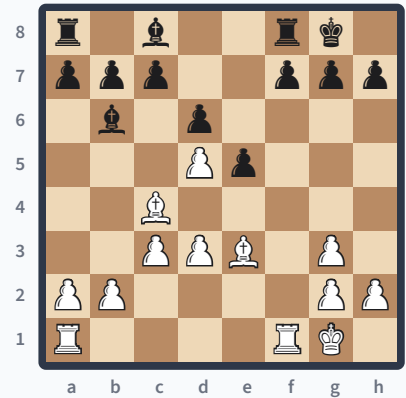
2 Black to move. Punish the mistake!



White (1535) v Black (1868) · 10+0
lichess.org/ya5llO7v

Answer:

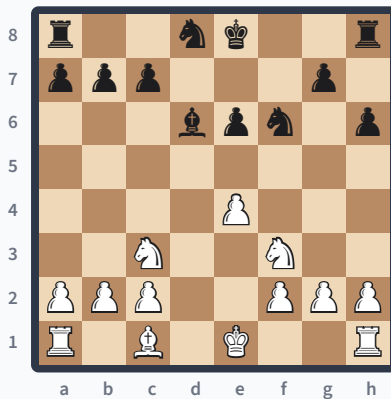
3 Black to move. Punish the mistake!



White (1611) v Black (1591) · 10+0
lichess.org/IC0EFtA5

Answer:

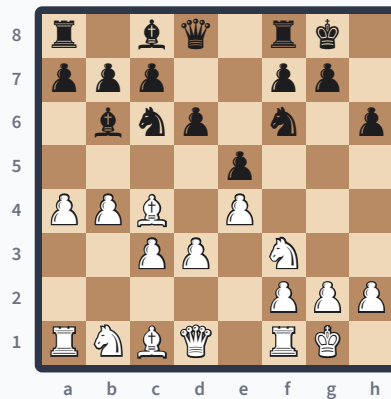
4 White to move. Punish the mistake!



White (1523) v Black (1535) · 15+0
lichess.org/3QG6DxRg

Answer:

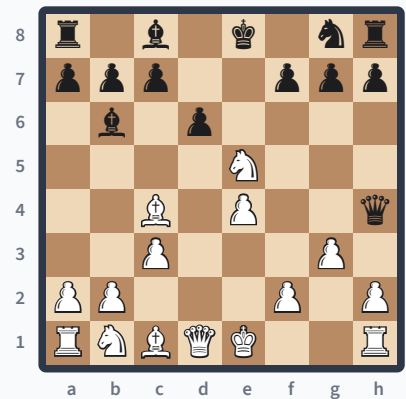
5 White to move. Punish the mistake!



White (1643) v Black (1457) · 10+0
lichess.org/rLWGpnk3

Answer:

6 Black to move. Punish the mistake!



White (1627) v Black (1574) · 10+0
lichess.org/lGAD4no4

Answer:

Tip: after every move, ask: "What did that move leave unguarded?" Checks and captures first!

Score: ____ / 6

THE SPANISH GAME

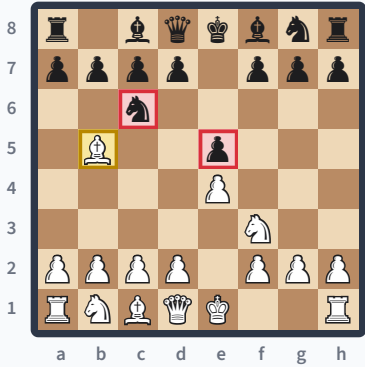
1.e4 e5 2.Nf3 Nc6 3.Bb5 • The Ruy Lopez: slow, steady pressure

Lesson 18 · Openings

Level 1 Opening Plans

1. Hit the Defender

3.BB5 EYES C6



1.e4 e5 2.Nf3 Nc6 3.Bb5

- The Knight on **c6** defends **e5**. The Bishop attacks that defender: "removing the defender" as an opening idea!
- Not a pin yet: the d7-pawn still stands between c6 and the King.

2. Not a Real Threat (Yet)

5...QD4! FORK

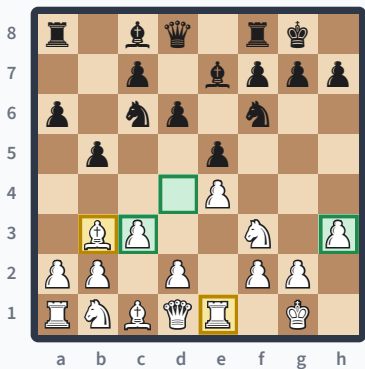


3...a6 4.Bxc6 dxc6 5.Nxe5? Qd4!

- Taking on c6 then e5 looks like it wins a pawn, but **5...Qd4!** forks the Knight and the **e4**-pawn.
- After 6.Nf3 Qxe4+ Black gets the pawn back. So White usually plays **4.Ba4**.

3. The Target Setup

C3 + H3, THEN D4



4.Ba4 Nf6 5.0-0 Be7 6.Re1 b5 7.Bb3 d6
8.c3 0-0 9.h3

- Castle early, **Re1** guards e4, the Bishop retreats to **b3** (aiming at f7 again!).
- **c3 + h3** prepare **d4**. Later: Nbd2-f1-g3.

4. Trap: Noah's Ark

8.QXD4?? BISHOP TRAPPED



4.Ba4 d6 5.d4 b5 6.Bb3 Nxd4 7.Nxd4 exd4
8.Qxd4?? c5 9.Qd5 Be6 10.Qc6+ Bd7 11.Qd5
c4

- Black's **a6**, **b5**, **c4** pawns build an "ark" around the **b3**-Bishop. It has no safe square left.
- Watch out when enemy pawns march toward your Bishop!

Italian vs. Spanish

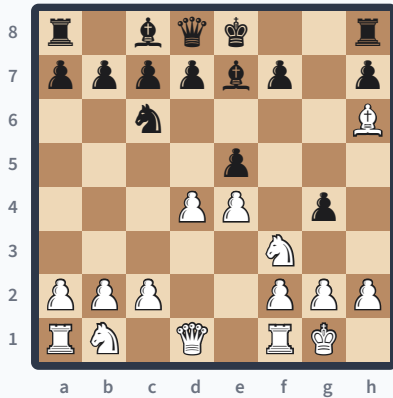
Feature	Italian (3.Bc4)	Spanish (3.Bb5)
Bishop aims at	f7, Black's weakest square	c6, the defender of e5
Speed	Quick attacks and tricks	Slow, long-lasting pressure
Shared plan	Castle → Re1 → c3 (+ h3) → d4, and bring the b1-Knight round via d2-f1-g3	

PUZZLES: SPANISH GAME

Six positions from real Lichess games

Lesson 18 · Openings Puzzles
Level 1 Opening Plans

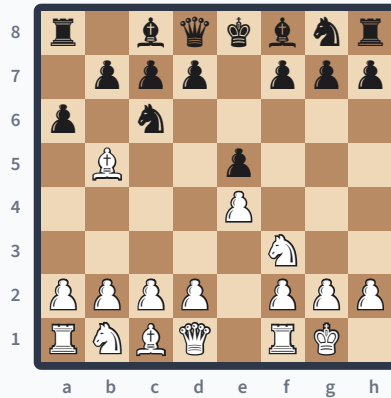
1 Black to move. Punish the mistake!



White (1106) v Black (1273) · 10+5
lichess.org/0lqJXRdN

Answer: _____

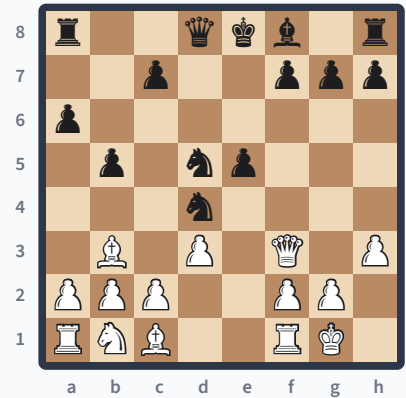
2 Black to move. Punish the mistake!



White (1167) v Black (1346) · 10+0
lichess.org/zZg84kcp

Answer: _____

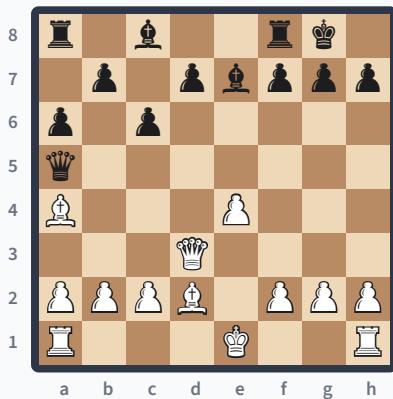
3 White to move. Punish the mistake!



White (1900) v Black (1647) · 10+15
lichess.org/3DpN699D

Answer: _____

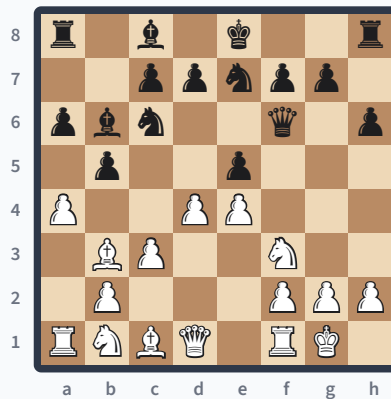
4 Black to move. Punish the mistake!



White (1289) v Black (2108) · 7+2
lichess.org/dJEtAQp7

Answer: _____

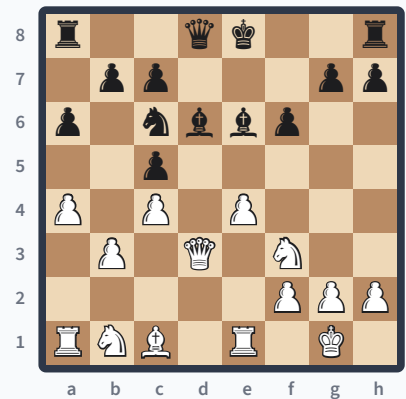
5 White to move. Punish the mistake!



White (1467) v Black (1454) · 10+0
lichess.org/mk0h2Gv8

Answer: _____

6 Black to move. Punish the mistake!



White (1975) v Black (1750) · 16+7
lichess.org/e22lAbXv

Answer: _____

Tip: after every move, ask: "What did that move leave unguarded?" Checks and captures first!

Score: ____ / 6

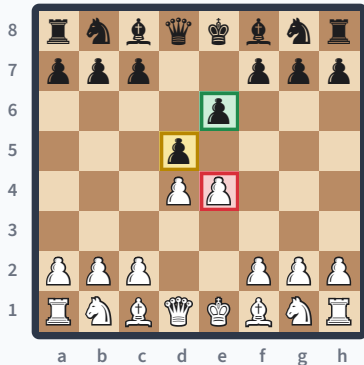
THE FRENCH DEFENCE

1.e4 e6 2.d4 d5 • Solid wall, then strike back at the centre

Lesson 19 • Openings
Level 1 Opening Plans

1. The Starting Moves

2...D5 HITS E4



1.e4 e6 2.d4 d5

- 1...e6 prepares 2...d5, which attacks e4. The e6-pawn backs it up.
- White must decide: push (3.e5), defend (3.Nc3) or trade (3.exd5 exd5, an equal, open game).

2. Advance: Hit the Base

3...C5! AT D4

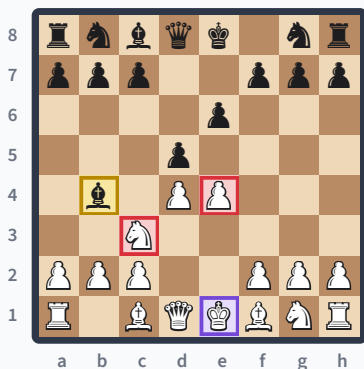


3.e5 c5!

- White's pawns form a chain: d4 holds up e5. Attack the chain at its base, d4.
- If d4 falls, e5 becomes weak too. Later, ...f6 can hit the head of the chain.

3. Winawer: Pin the Defender

3...Bb4 PINS C3



3.Nc3 Bb4

- 3.Nc3 defends e4. 3...Bb4 pins that Knight, so e4 is under real pressure again.
- Remember the pin handout: a pinned piece is a frozen defender.

4. The Target Setup

PILE UP ON D4



4.c3 Nc6 5.Nf3 Qb6 6.Be2 cxd4 7.cxd4 Nh6 8.Nc3 Nf5

- Nc6, Qb6, Nf5: three Black pieces attack d4, only two White pieces defend it.
- More attackers than defenders? Then take!

What Black Wants in the French

1. **Strike the centre:** ...c5 against d4 (the base), and later ...f6 against e5 (the head).
2. **Pressure d4:** ...Nc6, ...Qb6, ...Ne7-f5 or ...Nh6-f5. Pile up and count.
3. **Fix the "bad" Bishop:** the c8-Bishop is stuck behind e6. Trade it, or reroute it (...b6 and ...Ba6, or ...Bd7).

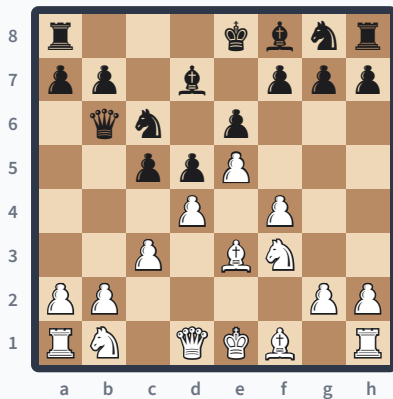
PUZZLES: FRENCH DEFENCE

Six positions from real Lichess games

Lesson 19 · Openings Puzzles

Level 1 Opening Plans

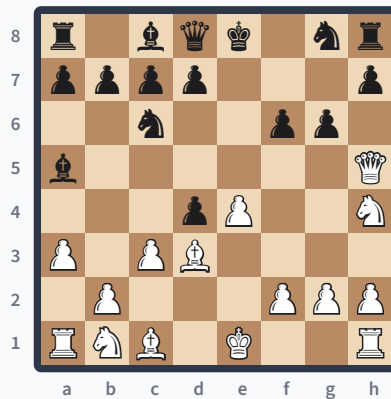
- 1** Black to move. Punish the mistake!



White (1681) v Black (1862) · 15+5
lichess.org/X2Bu7jwq

Answer: _____

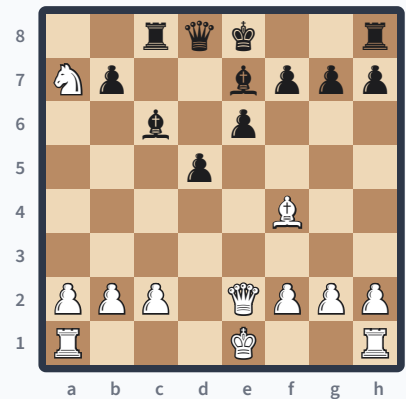
- 2** White to move. Punish the mistake!



White (1427) v Black (1343) · 10+10
lichess.org/r0KurW3d

Answer: _____

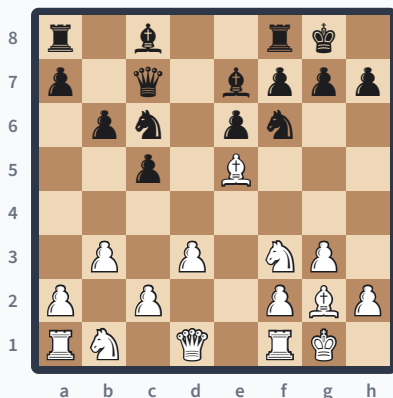
- 3** Black to move. Punish the mistake!



White (1713) v Black (1882) · 10+0
lichess.org/JUCyy41y

Answer: _____

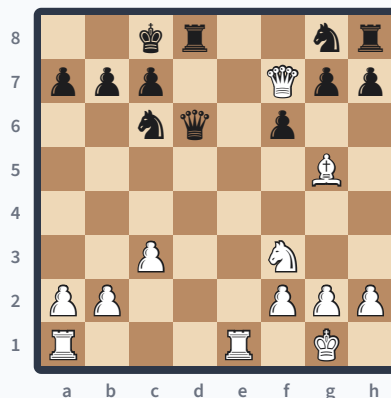
- 4** Black to move. Punish the mistake!



White (1949) v Black (2260) · 15+0
lichess.org/zEWTkqYd

Answer: _____

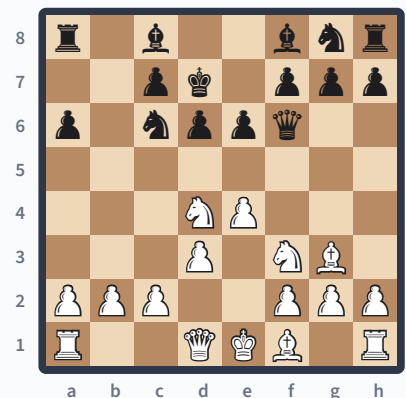
- 5** Black to move. Punish the mistake!



White (1401) v Black (1477) · 8+5
lichess.org/1FmqDby8

Answer: _____

- 6** Black to move. Punish the mistake!



White (1262) v Black (1184) · 10+0
lichess.org/AT83WBD9

Answer: _____

Tip: after every move, ask: "What did that move leave unguarded?" Checks and captures first!

Score: ____ / 6

THE DUTCH DEFENCE

1.d4 f5 • Grab e4, build a Stonewall, attack the King

Lesson 20 • Openings
Level 1 Opening Plans

1. The First Move

1...f5 CONTROLS E4



1.d4 f5

- Black stops White from playing e4, and gets ready for a kingside attack.
- The price: the e8-h5 diagonal is now open. Black's King must be careful (see panel 4).

2. Target Setup: The Stonewall

C6-D5-E6-F5 WALL



2.c4 Nf6 3.Nc3 e6 4.Nf3 d5 5.e3 c6 6.Bd3
Bd6 7.0-0 0-0

- Pawns on c6, d5, e6, f5 make a wall White can't easily break. Bd6 aims at the White King.
- Weak spot: the hole on e5. Keep White's Knights out!

3. The Attacking Plan

...QE8-H5 SWING

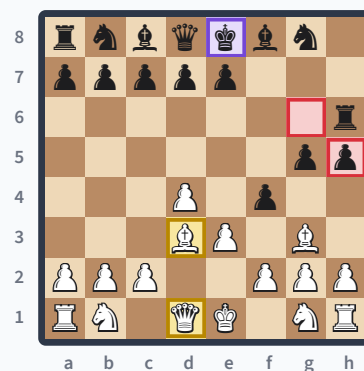


8.b3 Qe8 9.Bb2 Qh5

- The Queen swings via e8 to h5, eyeing h2 together with the d6-Bishop.
- Next ideas: ...Ne4 (the outpost f5 protects), ...Rf6-h6 or ...g5-g4 to open lines.

4. Trap: The Open Diagonal

7.QXH5+! MATES



2.Bg5 h6 3.Bh4 g5 4.Bg3 f4 5.e3 h5? 6.Bd3
Rh6?? 7.Qxh5+!

- Black pushed too many kingside pawns. 7...Rxh5 8.Bg6#, or 7...Rg6 8.Qxg6#.
- Don't rush ...g5 and ...h5. Castle first!

French vs. Dutch

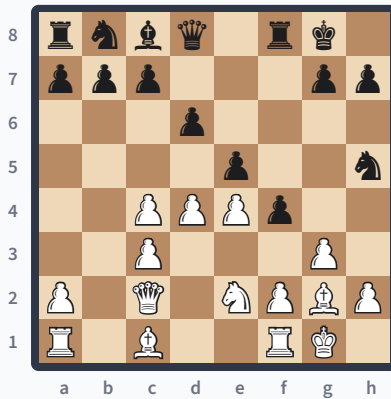
Feature	French (vs. 1.e4)	Dutch (vs. 1.d4)
First moves	...e6 and ...d5	...f5, then ...Nf6, ...e6, ...d5
Main plan	...c5 and pile up on d4	Hold e4, then attack the White King
Problem piece	c8-Bishop (behind e6)	c8-Bishop again: reroute ...Bd7-e8-h5
Watch out for	Attacks on your kingside after e5	Qh5+ on the open e8-h5 diagonal

PUZZLES: DUTCH DEFENCE

Six positions from real Lichess games

Lesson 20 · Openings Puzzles
Level 1 Opening Plans

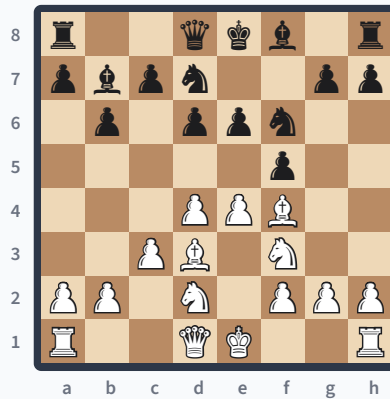
1 Black to move. Punish the mistake!



White (1812) v Black (1714) · 15+10
lichess.org/qJLrjD7k

Answer: _____

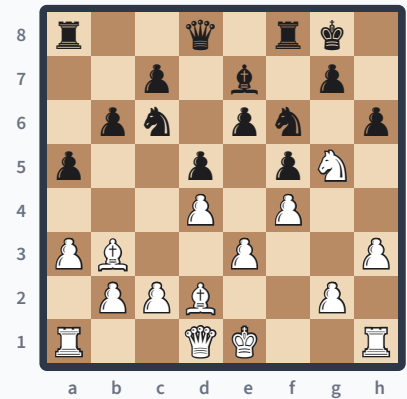
2 Black to move. Punish the mistake!



White (1839) v Black (1632) · 10+0
lichess.org/c9SiOFTa

Answer: _____

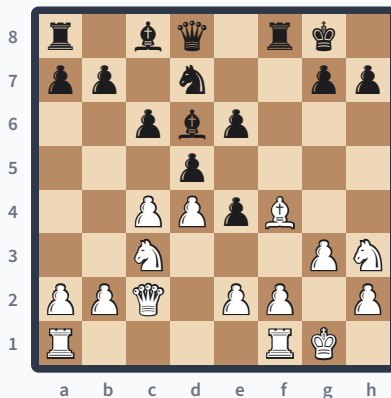
3 White to move. Punish the mistake!



White (1337) v Black (1458) · 5+5
lichess.org/uRizfqc3

Answer: _____

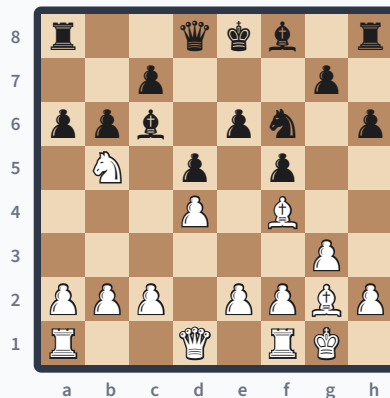
4 White to move. Punish the mistake!



White (1930) v Black (1912) · 10+0
lichess.org/92ClydvW

Answer: _____

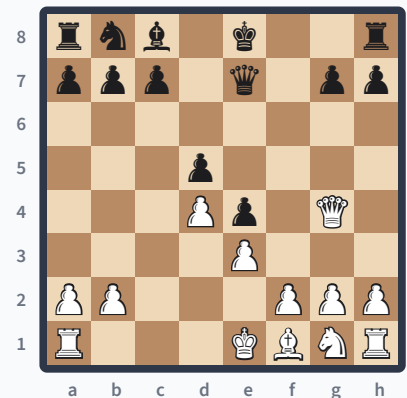
5 White to move. Punish the mistake!



White (1542) v Black (1842) · 10+0
lichess.org/tTEmNth0

Answer: _____

6 White to move. Punish the mistake!



White (1654) v Black (1573) · 20+3
lichess.org/FyrWLEm0

Answer: _____

Tip: after every move, ask: "What did that move leave unguarded?" Checks and captures first!

Score: ____ / 6

THE FRIED LIVER ATTACK

Two Knights Defence • Sacrifice on f7, drag the King out

Lesson 21 • Openings
Level 1 Opening Attacks

1. Two Attackers on f7

4.Ng5! HITS F7



1.e4 e5 2.Nf3 Nc6 3.Bc4 Nf6 4.Ng5

- Black's 3...Nf6 attacks e4. White ignores it and aims a second piece at f7.
- Knight + Bishop vs. the King alone: Black must block with 4...d5.

2. Black's Mistake

5...NXD5? NATURAL, BAD

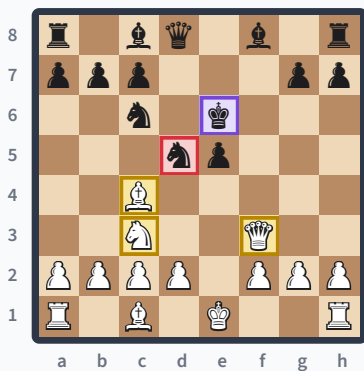


4...d5 5.exd5 Nxd5?

- Taking back looks normal, but the Knight on d5 is loose in the centre...
- ...and f7 is still guarded only by the King. Time for the sacrifice!

3. The Fried Liver

6.Nxf7! KING HUNT



6.Nxf7! Kxf7 7.Qf3+ Ke6 8.Nc3

- White gives a Knight to drag the King to e6. The Queen check forces it forward to guard d5.
- The d5-Knight is pinned and attacked 3 times. Black's King is in huge danger.

4. Black's Right Answer

5...NA5! HIT THE BISHOP



5...Na5! 6.Bb5+ c6 7.dxc6 bxc6

- Black kicks the c4-Bishop away from f7 instead of recapturing.
- White is a pawn up, but Black gets fast development and chases White's pieces.

Fried Liver Checklist

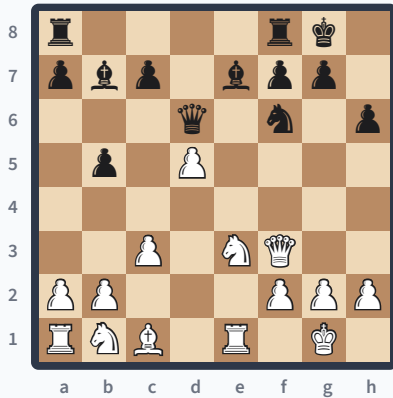
- White:** 4.Ng5 only works because f7 is weak. After 5...Nxd5?, sacrifice with Nxf7! and keep checking with the Queen.
- Black:** after 5.exd5, don't recapture. Play 5...Na5! and chase the Bishop.
- Watch out:** 4...Bc5!? (the Traxler) is a wild counter-attack on f2. Know it before you play 4.Ng5!

PUZZLES: FRIED LIVER

Six positions from real Lichess games

Lesson 21 · Openings Puzzles
Level 1 Opening Attacks

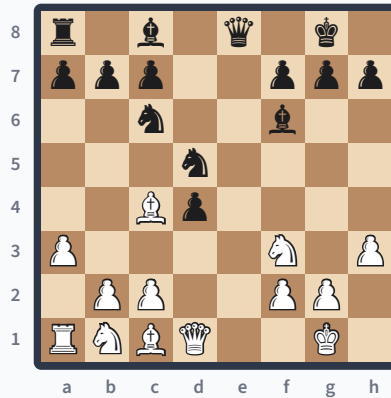
1 White to move. Punish the mistake!



White (2114) v Black (1867) · 10+0
lichess.org/3tC25kHR

Answer: _____

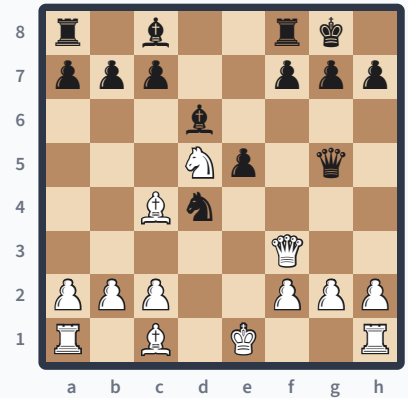
2 White to move. Punish the mistake!



White (2021) v Black (1711) · 15+10
lichess.org/S25mmjLL

Answer: _____

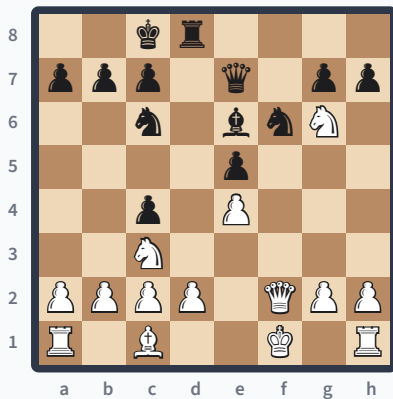
3 White to move. Punish the mistake!



White (1468) v Black (1484) · 5+8
lichess.org/gdF94tx2

Answer: _____

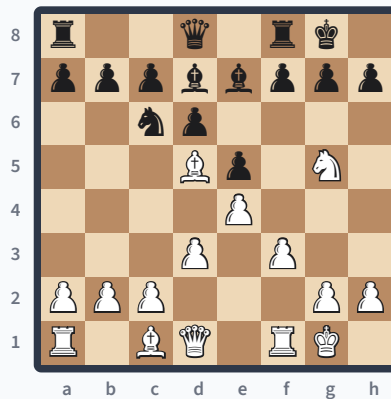
4 Black to move. Punish the mistake!



White (1730) v Black (1735) · 15+10
lichess.org/2TH890jR

Answer: _____

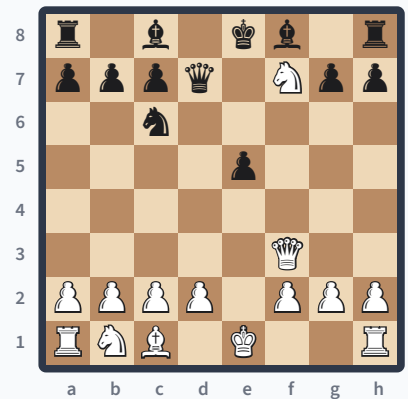
5 Black to move. Punish the mistake!



White (1305) v Black (2264) · 15+0
lichess.org/LcwYNoM6

Answer: _____

6 White to move. Punish the mistake!



White (1381) v Black (1401) · 15+15
lichess.org/e5E8qqz5

Answer: _____

Tip: after every move, ask: "What did that move leave unguarded?" Checks and captures first!

Score: ____ / 6

THE JOBAVA LONDON

1.d4 2.Nc3 3.Bf4 • The London System with a sharp edge

Lesson 22 • Openings
Level 1 Opening Attacks

1. The Setup

NC3 + BF4



1.d4 d5 2.Nc3 Nf6 3.Bf4

- Like the London (Bf4 early), but the Knight goes to **c3** instead of the c-pawn moving.
- The Bf4 already eyes **c7**. The Knight can jump to **b5** and hit it too.

2. The Nb5 Threat

4.NB5! EYES C7



3... e6 4.Nb5!

- Threat: **Nxc7+**, forking the King and the **a8**-Rook. The Bf4 backs the Knight up.
- Black must defend c7 now. The main answer is **4...Na6**.

3. Trap: The Fork on c7

5.NC7+! WINS ROOK



4... c6?? 5.Nc7+! Ke7 6.Nxa8

- 4...c6??** kicks the Knight but empties **c7**. The Knight lands with check and hits a8.
- Don't take it: **5...Qxc7??** 6.Bxc7 loses the Queen to the Bf4!

4. The Target Setup

E3, BD3, NF3



4.e3 Bd6 5.Bd3 0-0 6.Nf3

- Solid base: **d4 + e3**, Bishops on **f4** and **d3** aiming at the kingside, Knights out.
- Then: Qe2, castle long (O-O-O) and push the **g**- and **h**-pawns at Black's King.

Fried Liver vs. Jobava London

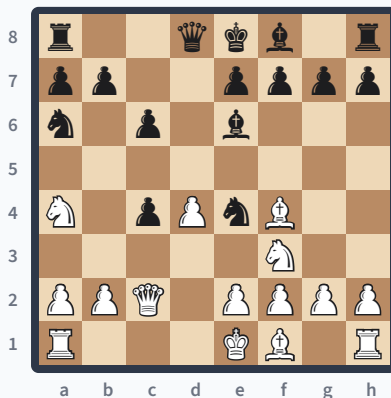
Feature	Fried Liver	Jobava London
First move	1.e4	1.d4
Target	f7 (the Black King)	c7 (the Knight fork on King + Rook)
Style	Sacrifice and attack at once	Solid setup with sneaky tricks
Key tactic	Pin (d5-Knight) + King hunt	Fork (Nc7+)

PUZZLES: JOBAVA LONDON

Six positions from real Lichess games

Lesson 22 · Openings Puzzles
Level 1 Opening Attacks

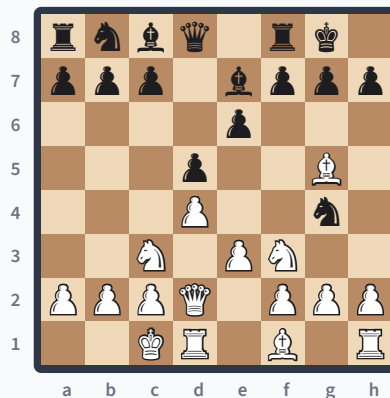
1 White to move. Punish the mistake!



White (1300) v Black (1279) · 10+0
lichess.org/lrmG0vHu

Answer: _____

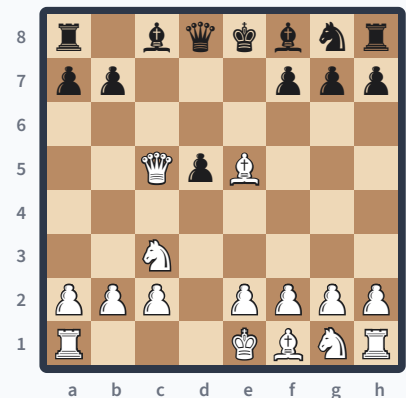
2 Black to move. Punish the mistake!



White (1099) v Black (1326) · 30+0
lichess.org/PYElSVY6

Answer: _____

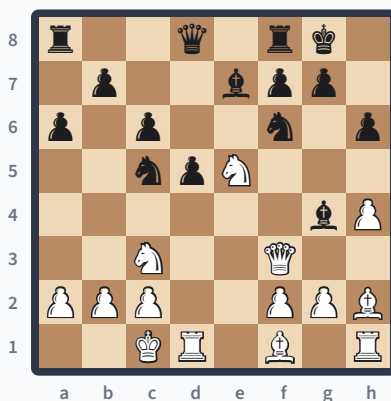
3 Black to move. Punish the mistake!



White (1349) v Black (1383) · 13+0
lichess.org/uOx3YYrc

Answer: _____

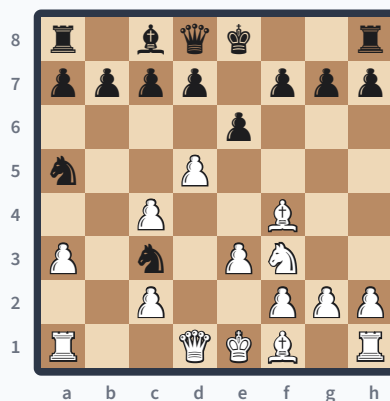
4 White to move. Punish the mistake!



White (1513) v Black (1802) · 11+0
lichess.org/9RDzo629

Answer: _____

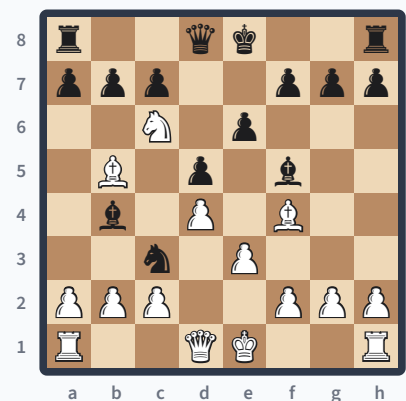
5 Black to move. Punish the mistake!



White (1242) v Black (1313) · 10+0
lichess.org/EIOiuATB

Answer: _____

6 White to move. Punish the mistake!



White (1794) v Black (951) · 30+5
lichess.org/XnXsJphk

Answer: _____

Tip: after every move, ask: "What did that move leave unguarded?" Checks and captures first!

Score: ____ / 6

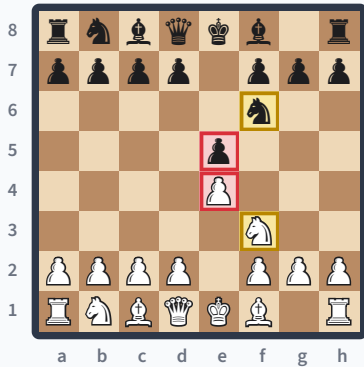
THE PETROV DEFENCE

1.e4 e5 2.Nf3 Nf6 • What White should do against it

Lesson 23 • Openings
Level 1 Opening Plans

1. The Counter-Attack

2...Nf6 HITS E4

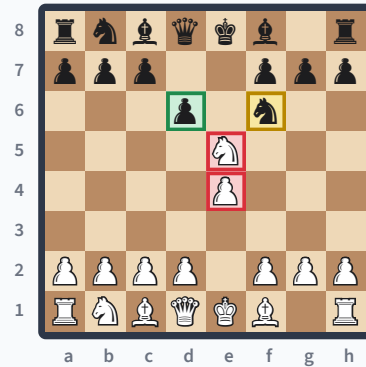


1.e4 e5 2.Nf3 Nf6

- Instead of defending e5, Black copies White and attacks e4.
- White's best: grab first with 3.Nxe5. Black's e5 is gone, White's e4 is still there.

2. Kick First, Then Take

3...d6! THE RIGHT ORDER

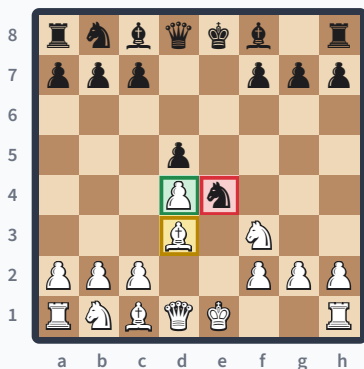


3.Nxe5 d6! 4.Nf3 Nxe4

- Black first kicks the e5-Knight home, and only then takes back the pawn on e4.
- If Black copies at once (3...Nxe4?), 4.Qe2! wins material. See the Discovered Attack handout (page 11)!

3. White's Plan

KICK THE E4 KNIGHT

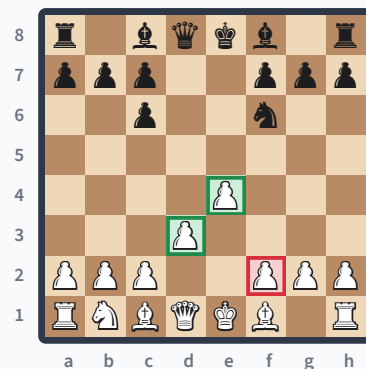


5.d4 d5 6.Bd3

- The Black Knight on e4 looks strong. White develops and attacks it: Bd3, O-O, Re1, then c4 or Nc3.
- Every attack on e4 gains time. Castle quickly: the e-file will open!

4. The Stafford Gambit

3...Nc6?! STAY CALM



3...Nc6?! 4.Nxc6 dxc6 5.d3!

- A trappy gambit. 5.d3! guards e4; then Be2 and O-O. White is a pawn up and safe.
- Greedy 5.e5 Ne4 6.d3 Bc5 7.dxe4?? loses to Bxf2+! 8.Kxf2 Qxd1.

Against the Petrov, White Should...

1. Take on e5 first (3.Nxe5), and punish copycat play with Qe2! on the open e-file.
2. Hit the e4-Knight with developing moves (Bd3, Re1, Nc3, c4). Each attack gains a tempo.
3. Don't get greedy against gambits: in the Stafford, guard e4 with d3 and castle. A safe pawn up is enough.

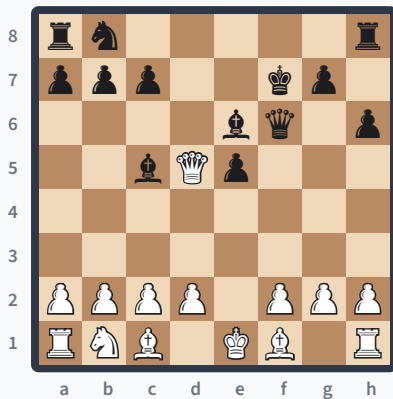
PUZZLES: PETROV DEFENCE

Six positions from real Lichess games

Lesson 23 · Openings Puzzles

Level 1 Opening Plans

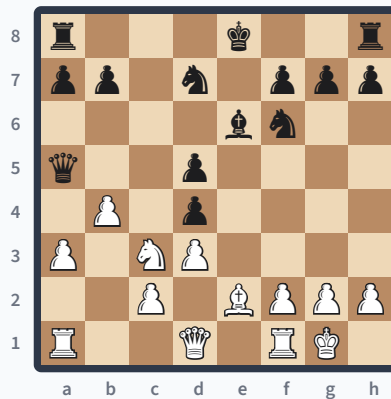
1 White to move. Punish the mistake!



White (1445) v Black (1345) · 10+5
lichess.org/9YESPIAn

Answer:

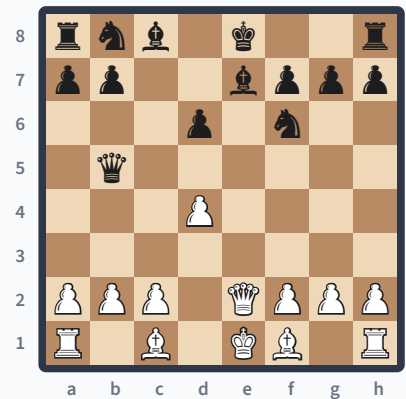
2 White to move. Punish the mistake!



White (1862) v Black (1736) · 15+10
lichess.org/gbwsKigN

Answer:

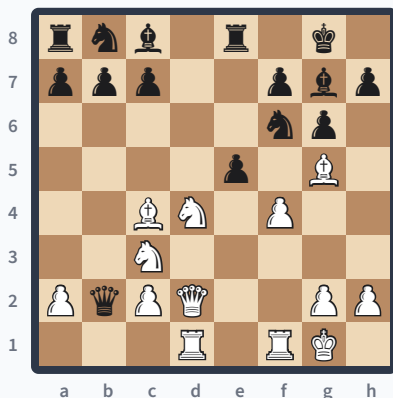
3 White to move. Punish the mistake!



White (1638) v Black (1409) · 7+2
lichess.org/GWoYshN7

Answer:

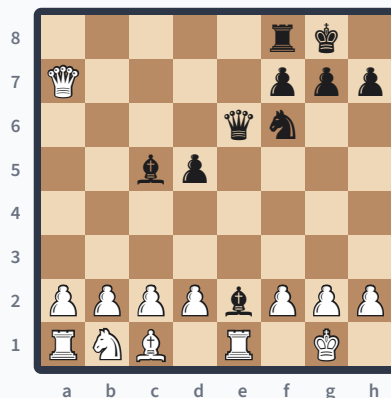
4 Black to move. Punish the mistake!



White (1532) v Black (1517) · 10+0
lichess.org/Fyz1UeYT

Answer:

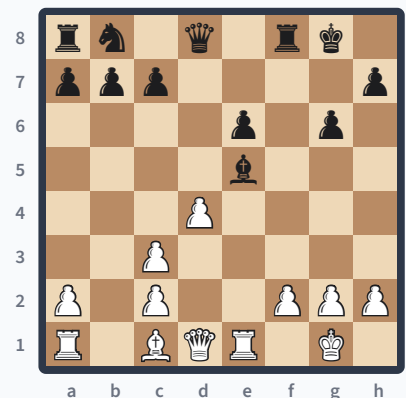
5 White to move. Punish the mistake!



White (1293) v Black (1282) · 10+0
lichess.org/cNLKsydT

Answer:

6 White to move. Punish the mistake!



White (2113) v Black (1838) · 10+0
lichess.org/DMLyB5io

Answer:

Tip: after every move, ask: "What did that move leave unguarded?" Checks and captures first!

Score: ____ / 6

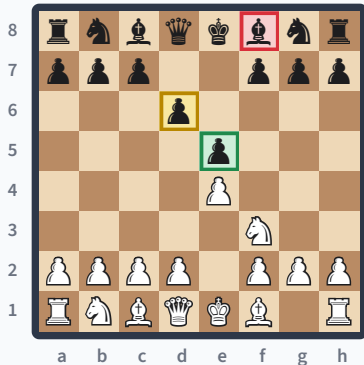
THE PHILIDOR DEFENCE

Lesson 24 • Openings
Level 1 Opening Plans

1.e4 e5 2.Nf3 d6 • What White should do against it

1. Solid but Passive

2...D6 GUARDS E5

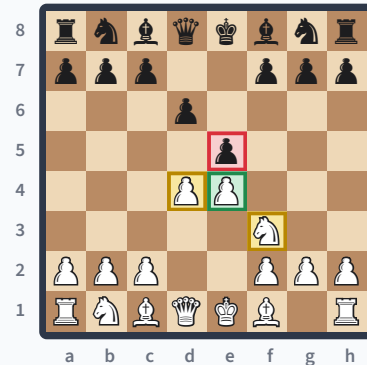


1.e4 e5 2.Nf3 d6

- Black defends e5 with a pawn instead of a Knight.
- Downside: the f8-Bishop is now blocked in, so Black develops slowly.

2. Hit the Centre

3.D4! BEST

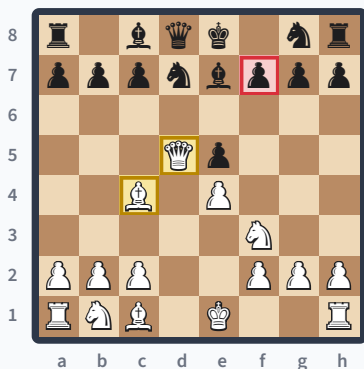


3.d4!

- Black is slow, so White strikes at once. 3.d4 attacks e5 a second time.
- Black must take (3...exd4, giving up the centre) or defend with 3...Nd7. Either way White has more space.

3. Trap: Queen to d5

6.QD5! THREAT QXF7#



3...Nd7 4.Bc4 Be7? 5.dxe5 dxe5 6.Qd5!

- Queen + Bishop hit f7 (sound familiar?). The threat is 7.Qxf7#.
- Black can stop the mate only by giving up material.

4. The Target Setup

SPACE + FAST DEVELOPMENT



4.Nxd4 Nf6 5.Nc3 Be7 6.Bc4 0-0 7.0-0

- After 3...exd4, take back with the Knight: a strong piece in the centre.
- Nc3, Bc4, castle, then Re1 and f4. Black is solid, but cramped.

Petrov vs. Philidor: White's Game Plan

Feature	Petrov (2...Nf6)	Philidor (2...d6)
Black's idea	Counter-attack e4	Hold e5 with a pawn
White's 3rd move	3.Nxe5, take first	3.d4!, grab the centre
White's plan	Develop and kick the e4-Knight	Use the extra space, develop fast
Trap to know	Qe2! vs. copycat ...Nxe4	Qd5! (and Qb3!) vs. f7

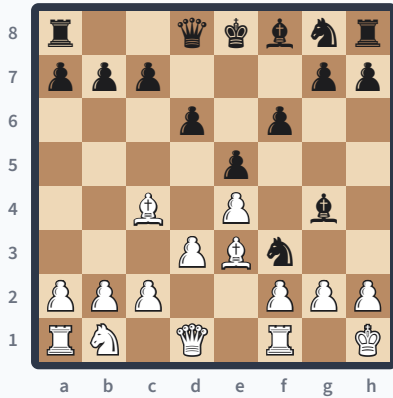
PUZZLES: PHILIDOR DEFENCE

Six positions from real Lichess games

Lesson 24 · Openings Puzzles

Level 1 Opening Plans

1 Black to move. Punish the mistake!



White (1023) v Black (1821) · 10+0
lichess.org/UnsR6Qcz

Answer: _____

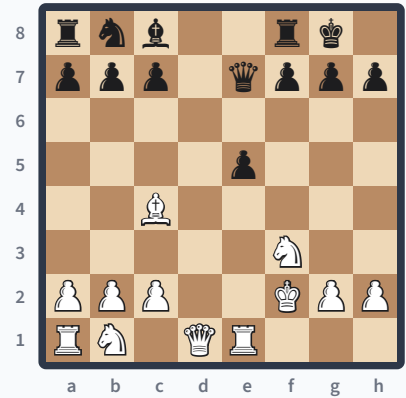
2 White to move. Punish the mistake!



White (1251) v Black (1166) · 10+0
lichess.org/u1vZFHL

Answer: _____

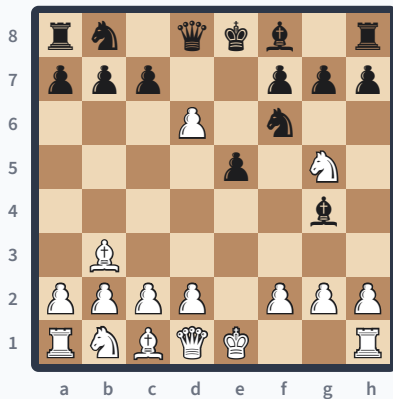
3 Black to move. Punish the mistake!



White (1651) v Black (1650) · 15+15
lichess.org/GK1U2Wtp

Answer: _____

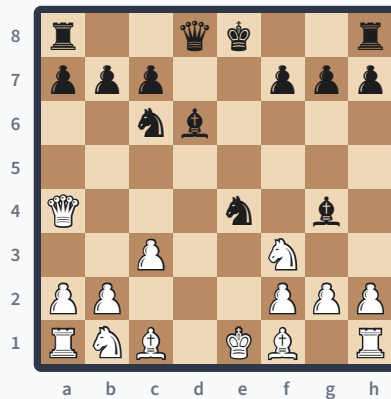
4 Black to move. Punish the mistake!



White (1101) v Black (1114) · 10+8
lichess.org/Mdl8pG69

Answer: _____

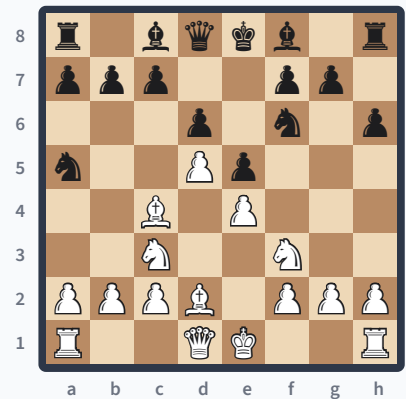
5 White to move. Punish the mistake!



White (1440) v Black (1421) · 10+4
lichess.org/57eOV6iY

Answer: _____

6 Black to move. Punish the mistake!



White (1506) v Black (1605) · 10+0
lichess.org/EiAbCtAi

Answer: _____

Tip: after every move, ask: "What did that move leave unguarded?" Checks and captures first!

Score: ____ / 6

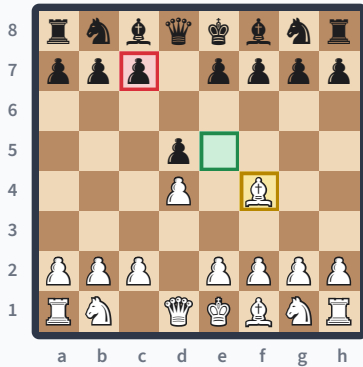
THE LONDON SYSTEM

1.d4 + 2.Bf4 • One setup against almost anything

Lesson 25 • Openings
Level 1 Opening Plans

1. Bishop Out First

2.BF4 BEFORE E3

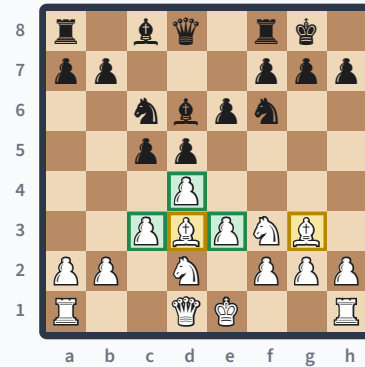


1.d4 d5 2.Bf4

- Get the dark-squared Bishop out **before** playing e3, or the e3-pawn will lock it in.
- On **f4** it controls **e5** and eyes **c7**. The same moves work against almost any Black reply.

2. The Target Setup

C3-D4-E3 PYRAMID

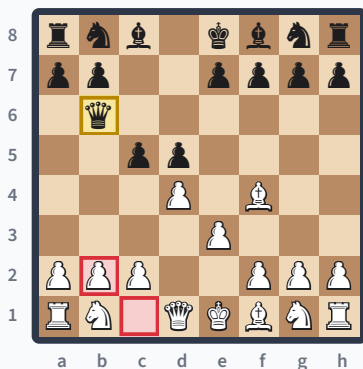


e3, Nf3, c3, Nbd2, Bd3, 0-0

- Pawns on **c3, d4, e3** make a rock-solid pyramid. Black can't easily break it.
- If Black plays ...Bd6 to trade, retreat **Bg3** and keep the Bishop.

3. Watch Out: ...Qb6!

B2 IS HANGING



2...c5 3.e3 Qb6!

- With the Bishop gone from c1, nothing guards **b2**. Defend it: **4.Qc1** or **4.Qb3**.
- Or 4.Nc3: if 4...Qxb2, **5.Nb5!** threatens Nc7+ (the Jobava fork!).

4. The Attacking Plan

NE5, THEN F4 + QF3



8.Nbd2 Qe7 9.Ne5!

- The Knight jumps to the strong **e5** square. **Bd3** and **Bg3** both aim at Black's King.
- Next: **f4** to support e5, then **Qf3-h3** or g4-g5 to attack.

The London Recipe

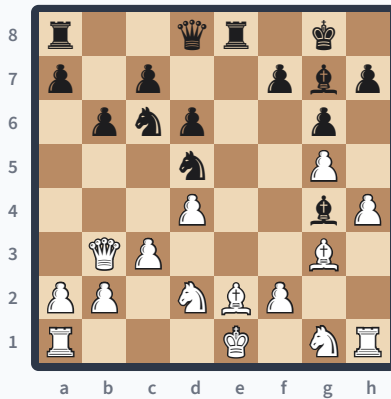
1. **Same first moves every game:** d4, Bf4, e3, Nf3, c3, Nbd2, Bd3, O-O. The order can change; the picture stays the same.
2. **Keep the good Bishop:** if ...Bd6 or ...Nh5 goes after it, answer with **Bg3**.
3. **Mind b2:** after Bf4, the b2-pawn is loose. Always check for ...Qb6!

PUZZLES: LONDON SYSTEM

Six positions from real Lichess games

Lesson 25 · Openings Puzzles
Level 1 Opening Plans

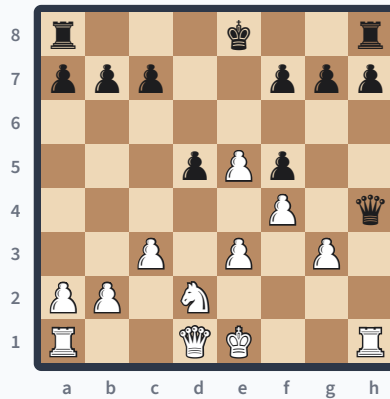
1 White to move. Punish the mistake!



White (1879) v Black (1844) · 10+0
lichess.org/jNrWtGX5

Answer: _____

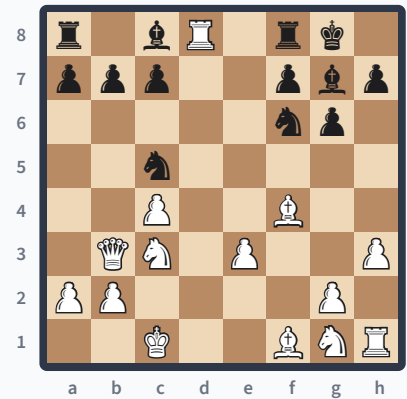
2 Black to move. Punish the mistake!



White (1931) v Black (1626) · 10+5
lichess.org/U4ZeQHim

Answer: _____

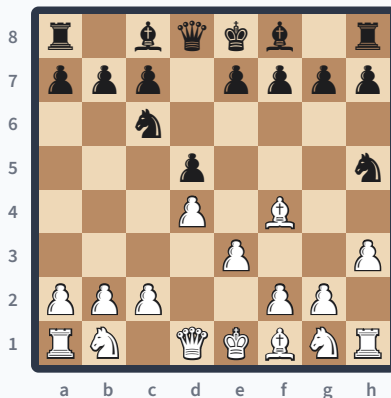
3 Black to move. Punish the mistake!



White (1451) v Black (1497) · 9+5
lichess.org/QiW7kLYI

Answer: _____

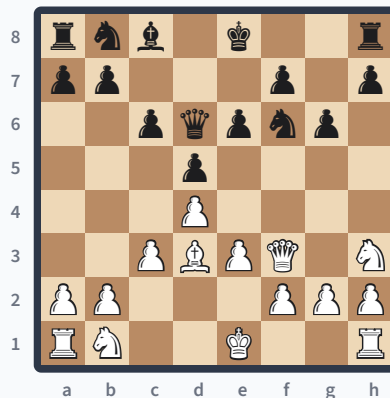
4 White to move. Punish the mistake!



White (1717) v Black (1699) · 10+3
lichess.org/mYIKv9zs

Answer: _____

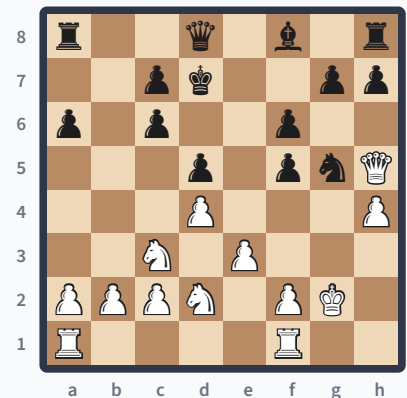
5 White to move. Punish the mistake!



White (1160) v Black (946) · 15+15
lichess.org/jZg3LqpE

Answer: _____

6 White to move. Punish the mistake!



White (1621) v Black (1600) · 5+5
lichess.org/6HdRGr8F

Answer: _____

Tip: after every move, ask: "What did that move leave unguarded?" Checks and captures first!

Score: ____ / 6

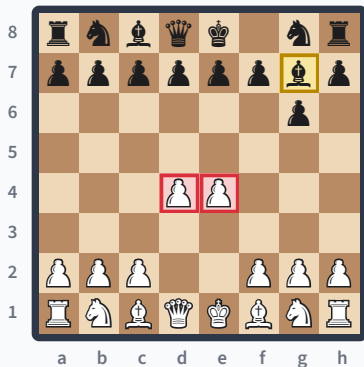
THE MODERN DEFENCE

1...g6 + 2...Bg7 • Let White build a centre, then attack it

Lesson 26 • Openings
Level 1 Opening Plans

1. The Fianchetto

BG7 ON THE LONG DIAGONAL

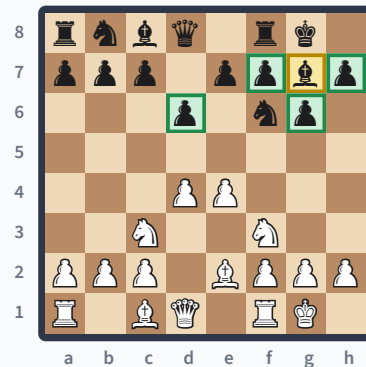


1.e4 g6 2.d4 Bg7

- Black lets White take the centre on purpose. The Bishop on **g7** already aims at **d4**.
- Works against 1.e4, 1.d4 or 1.c4: the same setup every game.

2. The Target Setup

D6, Nf6, CASTLE



3.Nc3 d6 4.Nf3 Nf6 5.Be2 0-0 6.0-0

- The King hides behind **f7, g6, h7** and the Bishop: a very safe castle.
- **d6** stops e4-e5 for now. (With an early ...Nf6 this is also called the Pirc.)

3. Strike the Centre

...c5! HITS D4



3.Nf3 d6 4.Be2 c5!

- The **c5**-pawn and the **g7**-Bishop both attack **d4**. White must deal with it.
- The other break is **...e5**. One of the two, played at the right time, is the whole plan!

4. Watch Out: Bh6!

BE3 + QD2 + BH6



4.Be3 Nf6 5.Qd2 0-0 6.Bh6

- White trades off Black's best defender, the **g7**-Bishop, then storms with h4-h5.
- Answer fast in the centre: **...c5** or **...e5**. Against this setup, don't castle too early.

London vs. Modern

Feature	London (White)	Modern (Black)
Core moves	d4, Bf4, e3, Nf3, c3, Bd3	...g6, ...Bg7, ...d6, ...Nf6, ...O-O
Centre	Hold it with pawns	Let White take it, then attack it
Key break / plan	Ne5, f4 and a kingside attack	...c5 or ...e5 at the right time
Watch out for	...Qb6 hitting b2	Be3, Qd2, Bh6 and an h-pawn storm

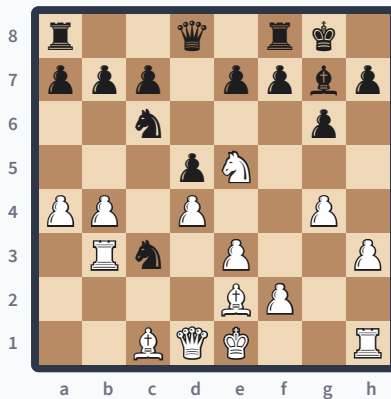
PUZZLES: MODERN DEFENCE

Six positions from real Lichess games

Lesson 26 · Openings Puzzles

Level 1 Opening Plans

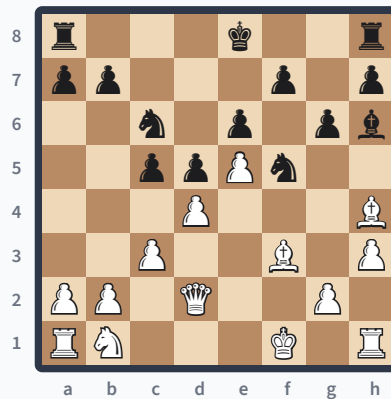
1 Black to move. Punish the mistake!



White (979) v Black (1164) · 15+15
lichess.org/LWWtcZAB

Answer:

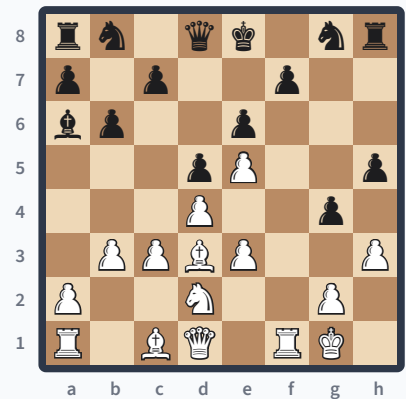
2 Black to move. Punish the mistake!



White (2103) v Black (2294) · 10+3
lichess.org/TJLmNonU

Answer:

3 Black to move. Punish the mistake!



White (1634) v Black (1526) · 10+0
lichess.org/GaGoYzaA

Answer:

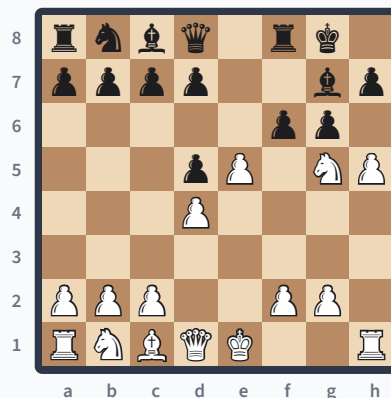
4 Black to move. Punish the mistake!



White (1527) v Black (1706) · 10+0
lichess.org/QlgdDutd

Answer:

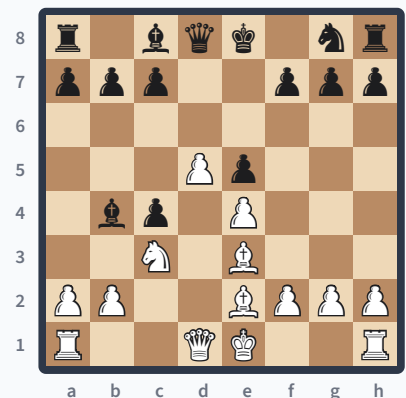
5 Black to move. Punish the mistake!



White (1686) v Black (1723) · 10+0
lichess.org/OsKXXcYe

Answer:

6 White to move. Punish the mistake!



White (1445) v Black (1431) · 10+5
lichess.org/CEAwz9AD

Answer:

Tip: after every move, ask: "What did that move leave unguarded?" Checks and captures first!

Score: ____ / 6

SOLUTIONS

All puzzle answers · Each game link is printed under its puzzle

No peeking
until you've tried!

1. Scholar's Mate p. 2

- 1 Qxf7#
- 2 Qxf7#: the Qf3 version works against the Sicilian too
- 3 Qxf7#: the Wayward Queen order, Qh5 first
- 4 Qh5 or Qf3: both aim at f7 together with the Bishop. The game went 4.Qh5 Nc6?? 5.Qxf7#
- 5 Qf7# (played) or Bf7#: the f-pawn has gone, so no capture needed
- 6 Bxf2# (played) or Qxf2#: Queen + Bishop against f2

2. Stopping Scholar's Mate p. 4

- 1 g6! kicks the Queen (or Qe7/Qf6). The game went 3...Nf6?? 4.Qxf7#
- 2 Qe7 or Qf6: each guards both f7 and e5. The game went 3...Bb4?? 4.Qxf7#
- 3 Nf6! blocks and develops (or Qe7/Qf6). The game went 3...Na6?? 4.Qxf7#
- 4 Nf6! (or Qe7/Qf6). 4...Nd4?? hit the Queen but forgot f7: 5.Qxf7#
- 5 e6 or d5 blocks the Bishop, g6 kicks the Queen. The game went 3...h6?? 4.Qxf7#
- 6 Nf3! (or Qf3/Qe2). The game went 4.Nc3?? Qxf2#

3. The Fork p. 6

- 1 23...Nd2+ 24.Kg2 Nxe4, wins 9 points
- 2 3.Qxe5+ Qe7 4.Qxh8, wins 6 points
- 3 17...Nxc2+ 18.Kd2 Nxa1, wins 6 points
- 4 5.Qa4+ b5 6.Qxb4, wins 3 points
- 5 9.Nc7+ Kd8 10.Nxb5, wins 7 points
- 6 22...Qxe2+ 23.Kxa3 Qxe4, wins 5 points

4. The Pin p. 8

- 1 7.Bb5 Bh3 8.Bxc6+, wins 6 points
- 2 10.Bb5 Bd7 11.Bxc6, wins 6 points
- 3 20.Bf3 b5 21.Bxe4, wins 3 points
- 4 12...Bxe5 13.Ba3 Bxc3, wins 3 points
- 5 30...Qe1+ 31.Rf1 Qxe2, wins 3 points
- 6 8...Bxc3 9.Ne2 Bxd2+, wins 3 points

5. The Skewer p. 10

- 1 20...Bc4 21.Qe4 Bxf1, wins 3 points
- 2 18.Bf3 Qxc4 19.Bxb7, wins 4 points
- 3 23.Ra8+ Ke7 24.Rxg8
- 4 56.Ra4+ Ke3 57.Rxf4, wins 5 points
- 5 38...Bh3+ 39.Kh2 Bxf1, wins 2 points
- 6 18...b1=Q+ 19.Ke2 Qxh1, wins 13 points

6. Discovered Attack p. 12

- 1 50.Nf8+ Kf5 51.Rxh5+, wins 5 points
- 2 30.Nxc6+ Kxc6 31.Na7+, wins 5 points
- 3 39...Kd6+ 40.Re4 Bxe4+, wins 5 points
- 4 13.exd5+ Ne7 14.dxc6, wins 9 points
- 5 31...dxe3+ 32.Nd4 exd2, wins 3 points
- 6 33...Rxf3 34.Rxg4 Qh3+

7. Back-Rank Mate p. 14

- 1 25...Qh1#
- 2 11...Qd1#
- 3 40.Qa8#
- 4 24...Rd1+ 25.Re1 Rxe1#
- 5 31...Qg1+ 32.Bf1 Qxf1#
- 6 30...Rb1+ 31.Bd1 Rxd1#

8. Removing the Defender p. 16

- 1 14.Bxe6 Qxe6 15.bxc5, wins 2 points
- 2 9.Bxc6+ bxc6 10.Qxd4, wins 9 points
- 3 17...Bxf3 18.Qxf3 Qxe5, wins 5 points
- 4 11...Qxf4+ 12.Ke1 Qxc7, wins 6 points
- 5 24...Nxf4 25.Rxf4 Qxg5, wins 9 points
- 6 12.Bxe6 Nxf2 13.Bxf7+, wins 3 points

9. Pawn Weaknesses p. 18

- 1 White 3 (a-b, d, g-h), Black 2
- 2 f2 and f3
- 3 d5: no Black pawn on the c- or e-file
- 4 g6 and g7: doubled, with no f- or h-pawn
- 5 b2 (chain b2-c3-d4). Bonus: b2 and b3 are doubled
- 6 Base a7, head d4 (chain a7-b6-c5-d4)

10. Pawn Chains & Captures p. 20

- 1 hxg6! (2 islands instead of 3, no new isolated pawn; the game went fxg6?)
- 2 dxc3! (2 islands instead of 3, no new isolated pawn)
- 3 dxc6! (2 islands instead of 3, no new isolated pawn)
- 4 axb3! (1 island instead of 2)
- 5 hxg6! (1 island instead of 2)
- 6 exf5! (no new isolated pawn)

11. How to Promote p. 22

- 1 84...g2 85.Kh2 Kf2
- 2 50.e5 Kg5 51.Ke6
- 3 54...Kh3 55.b7 g3
- 4 61.Kg4 Ke5 62.Kg5
- 5 60.Kh7 Ke6 61.g8=Q+
- 6 79.f7 Kg7 80.Ke7

12. How to Get Stalemated p. 24

- 1 99.Kg1 Kg4 100.Kg2
- 2 53.Ke2 Kf4 54.Kf2
- 3 57.Kd2 c3+ 58.Kc2
- 4 54...a5 55.g6 Kg8
- 5 97...Kh8 98.Kf5 Kh7
- 6 50...Kh5 51.Kf3 g5

13. Basic Checkmates p. 26

- 1 53.Qg8+ Kh3 54.Rh7#
- 2 59...c1=Q+ 60.Ka2 Qb2# (c1=N?? stalemate)
- 3 66.Kd6 b3 67.Rh8#
- 4 62.Qb2# (Qb3?? stalemate)
- 5 59...Qd7# (Ke5??, Rb8??, Rb4?? stalemate)
- 6 51.Re8#

14. Famous Mating Patterns p. 28

- 1 18...Rxb2#: Arabian mate
- 2 26...Rxa2#: Arabian mate
- 3 32...Rxb2#: Anastasia's mate
- 4 30...Qxb2#: Anastasia's mate
- 5 16...Bg4#: two Bishops mate
- 6 25.Ngh6#: two Knights mate

15. Fool's Mate & the Shilling p. 30

- 1 2...Qh4#
- 2 2...Qh4#: Fool's Mate
- 3 4...Qg5! hits e5 and g2
- 4 No! 4.Nxd4 (played) or 4.O-O
- 5 5.Bxf7+ (played) or 5.O-O; not 5.Nxf7??
- 6 9...Nf3#: smothered mate

16. Lasker Trap & Fishing Pole p. 32

- 1 6.fxe3! (played); 6.Bxb4?? exf2+
- 2 7...fxg1=N+! (example line)
- 3 8...Bg4+ skewers King and Queen (example line)
- 4 No! 6.c3 (played) or 6.d4; hxg4? opens the h-file
- 5 7...Qh4! The game went 8.g3?? Qxh2#
- 6 10...Qh4! 11.f3 g3 12.Nd2 Qh1#

17. Italian Game p. 34

- 1 14...Rxd8 15.Nb5 dxe5, wins 3 points
- 2 12...Nxe4 13.Qc2 Qxh4, wins 4 points
- 3 13...Bxe3+ 14.Kh1 Bh6, wins 3 points
- 4 11.e5 Nd5 12.exd6
- 5 9.a5 Bd4 10.cxd4, wins 2 points
- 6 8...Qxe4+ 9.Kd2 dxe5, wins 4 points

18. Spanish Game p. 36

- 1 8...gxf3 9.Qxf3 exd4, wins 3 points
- 2 4...axb5 5.Re1 Be7, wins 3 points
- 3 11.Qxd5 Qxd5 12.Bxd5, wins 3 points
- 4 12...Qxa4 13.c4 c5, wins 3 points
- 5 10.axb5 Na5 11.dxe5, wins 2 points
- 6 12...Bxh2+ 13.Nxh2 Qxd3, wins 7 points

19. French Defence p. 38

- 1 7...Qxb2 8.dxc5 Qxa1, wins 5 points
- 2 9.Nxg6 hxg6 10.Qxh8, wins 3 points
- 3 14...Qa5+ 15.c3 Qxa7, wins 3 points
- 4 11...Nxe5 12.Nxe5 Qxe5, wins 3 points
- 5 15...fxg5 16.Qxg7 Nge7, wins 2 points
- 6 8...Nxd4 9.Nd2 Nc6, wins 3 points

20. Dutch Defence p. 40

- 1 11...f3 12.Bxf3 Rxf3
- 2 8...fxe4 9.Nxe4 Nxe4, wins 3 points
- 3 15.Nxe6 Qc8 16.Nxf8, wins 3 points
- 4 11.Bxd6 e5 12.Bxf8, wins 3 points
- 5 11.Nxc7+ Kf7 12.Nxa8, wins 3 points
- 6 10.Qxc8+ Kf7 11.Qf5+, wins 3 points

21. Fried Liver Attack p. 42

- 1 15.Nf5 Qd7 16.Nxe7+, wins 6 points
- 2 12.Bxd5 Bf5 13.Bc4, wins 3 points
- 3 10.Bxg5 Nxf3+ 11.gxf3, wins 3 points
- 4 11...hxg6 12.Nb5 Kb8, wins 3 points
- 5 10...Bxg5 11.f4 exf4, wins 3 points
- 6 9.Nxh8 Bd6 10.Qh5+, wins 5 points

22. Jobava London p. 44

- 1 8.Qxe4 Bd5 9.Qb1, wins 3 points
- 2 8...Bxg5 9.Nxg5 Qxg5, wins 3 points
- 3 6...Bxc5 7.Bxg7 d4, wins 8 points
- 4 15.Nxg4 Nxg4 16.Qxg4, wins 3 points
- 5 9...Nxd1 10.Rxd1 d6, wins 6 points
- 6 9.Nxd8+ Nxb5+ 10.Kf1, wins 4 points

23. Petrov Defence p. 46

- 1 10.Qxc5 Nc6 11.c3, wins 3 points
- 2 15.bxa5 dxc3 16.d4, wins 6 points
- 3 11.Qxb5+ Nc6 12.c3, wins 9 points
- 4 13...exd4 14.Nb5 Bf5, wins 3 points
- 5 14.Qxc5 Qg4 15.h3, wins 3 points
- 6 12.Rxe5 Qd7 13.Bh6, wins 3 points

24. Philidor Defence p. 48

- 1 8...Nxh2 9.f3 Nxf1, wins 3 points
- 2 6.Nxf7 Nxe4 7.Nxd8, wins 1 point
- 3 10...Qc5+ 11.Re3 Qxc4, wins 2 points
- 4 7...Bxd1 8.Bxf7+ Kd7, wins 8 points
- 5 8.Qxe4+ Qe7 9.Qxe7+, wins 3 points
- 6 7...Nxc4 8.Bc1 Nb6, wins 3 points

25. London System p. 50

- 1 13.Qxd5 Qe7 14.f3, wins 3 points
- 2 14...Qxh1+ 15.Ke2 Qxd1+, wins 5 points
- 3 13...Nxb3+ 14.axb3 Rxd8, wins 10 points
- 4 5.Qxh5 Nb4 6.Qd1, wins 3 points
- 5 9.Qxf6 Qf8 10.Qf4, wins 3 points
- 6 15.hxg5 g6 16.Qd1, wins 3 points

26. Modern Defence p. 52

- 1 12...Nxd1 13.Nxc6 bxc6, wins 9 points
- 2 14...Bxd2 15.Nxd2 Nxh4, wins 9 points
- 3 14...Bxd3 15.e4 dxe4, wins 3 points
- 4 11...bxa4 12.Qe2 Nb8, wins 3 points
- 5 9...fxg5 10.hxg6 hxg6, wins 3 points
- 6 9.Qa4+ Bd7 10.Qxb4, wins 3 points